Cast-a-Shadow

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/34002499.

Rating:	General Audiences
Archive Warning:	No Archive Warnings Apply
Category:	F/F
Fandom:	She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)
Relationships:	Castaspella/Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Castaspella & Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)
Characters:	Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Castaspella (She-Ra), Micah (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Double Trouble (She-Ra)
Additional Tags:	Angst and Hurt/Comfort, Fluff and Hurt/Comfort, post She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018) Season 5, Potential Spoilers, References to Canon, Shadow Weaver being honest, castaweaver, Summoning, spirit Shadow Weaver, Someone please restrain Micah, Sorry for only including one kiss, but please enjoy the pining and flirting, For the Love of Shadow Weaver (She-Ra), Hurt no comfort in the last chapter, the sequel shall bring the comfort tho, Regretting arc, Enemies to Friends to Lovers, how could I forget that tag? omgs
Language:	English
Series:	Part 2 of Post-war: Path 1
Stats:	Published: 2021-10-06 Completed: 2021-12-29 Words: 28,111 Chapters: 13/13

Cast-a-Shadow

by Xenakis (IceRosesCrown)

Summary

As Etheria recovers from the war, all inhabitants little by little fall into calm and careless lives, finally able to enjoy their hard-won peace. The kingdoms are more united and even Mystacor feels safe enough to drop their shield, collaborate with other kingdoms, and reconnect with the world beneath them.

However, someone seems uneasy in this world, feeling it lost someone who was still needed.
»—Here again?
»Micah found his sister, once again, at the Lunarium, just looking up to the sky through the oculus in the ceiling. She sighs and turns to face him, her expression clearly tired.
»—Did you need anything?— she asks him in a gentle tone.
»—No, I… supposed you'd be here. Just tell me, Castaspella. What's bothering you?
»—I… It's nothing, Micah, don't worry.
»—Please.
»—I *can't* answer you— she insists, her expression pained as she turns around.
»Micah walks up to her and places a hand on her shoulder.
»—If I had to guess… I'd say maybe you… miss Shadow Weaver?

Disclaimer: Can't believe I have to say this but ***I'm not at all defending or downplaying SW's actions****, if anything, I'm holding her accountable, as she should've been.*

Notes

Credits:
- The title deserves proper credits from this tweet, I consider it particularly smart.
- The idea of Shadow Weaver being a spirit should be credited to this fanart I saw *years* ago, and now I just wanted to work with the idea and decided to make it like she had been summoned.
- And last, but not less important, I recently found out Shadow Weaver has a canon "real" name, but from the *Masters of the Universe* lore. The 2018 She-Ra reboot presents several differences in lore, one of the most notorious being castasweaver's backstory. Yes, originally they kinda had shared past because they studied together, while in our beloved reboot Castaspella was a toddler when Shadow Weaver got corrupted, and their original backstory is merely hinted in *In the Shadows of Mystacor*. So, in honor of the only canon name in the whole universe of She-Ra and associated series, I'll be including it too because it's simply beautiful.

Finally, this fic *should* be considered a sequel to *Behind the Mask* as I make quite a number of references to that "invented" scene I imagined could have occurred. Anyways, no need to read it but the experience will certainly be different.

Without further ado, please enjoy.

The Summoning - Part 1

The calmness of a world free of war has slowly become more and more normal. The people of Etheria can enjoy freedom every day, don't need to fear any sudden attacks, the Horde and Horde Prime are remembered as bad nightmares, and everyone from the Fright Zone adapts to their new lives, a clean slate. For the kingdoms, the only threat to their people are the now-awakened magical creatures, fearful after centuries asleep, and scared to find so many people out in the wild.

With the dawn of a new era, Etheria starts to implement what the war times taught them, and now Mystacor is more open to helping with the new surge in magic below them. Bright Moon, finally, established more fluent relations with them, with Micah becoming a tutor and Queen Glimmer a part of Mystacor's council. Castaspella is still the Head Sorceress, the Guild chose to keep her, even if she insisted her brother would be better suited, so instead, he acts as an advisor.

—Here again?

Micah found his sister, once again, at the Lunarium, just looking up to the sky through the oculus in the ceiling. She sighs and turns to face him, her expression clearly tired.

—Did you need anything?— she asks him in a gentle tone.

—No, I… supposed you'd be here. Just tell me, Castaspella. What's bothering you?

—I… It's nothing, Micah, don't worry.

—Please.

—I *can't* answer you— she insists, her expression pained as she turns around.

Micah walks up to her and places a hand on her shoulder.

—If I had to guess… I'd say maybe you… miss Shadow Weaver?

Castaspella automatically turns around and away from his touch.

—I don't… Why would I?— she replies, her face completely red. —If that's what you think, maybe *you* are the one who misses her?

Micah took a deep breath before answering.

—Many years ago, decades now, I missed her, yes. My tutor, Light Spinner, died the day she got corrupted, and the last thing she did was caressing my cheek before vanishing. Whoever she became afterward, whoever Shadow Weaver was and did, that's not the person I knew, so I don't care for her death, even if now it's real; I've already cried, I've already missed her, for me she's been long dead— he responds with severity. Then his expression softens a bit as he

continues —But you only met her recently, even if I don't like to admit it, so Shadow Weaver is the only version of her you've ever known. I remember all you told me about how you really got to know her when you were investigating the Crystal of Arxia, and you are right, Light Spinner was nothing like the stories you were told. I…—. He hesitated a moment before admitting —I know you were told exaggerated stories because everyone feared you, like me, would have some sort of weakness for her. And you still allowed yourself to know her, so maybe, just maybe, now you miss her. No one expected her to sacrifice herself, perhaps you had things to discuss with her and still need closure.

Castaspella lets out a faint smile and looks back at him.

—I appreciate it, but I did also tell you we spoke one last time before… that. So I don't understand what I'm feeling, or why even— she explains, as her expression shows more confusion.

Once again, Micah had to take a deep breath to muster the strength for what he was about to say.

—Sis, I want to help you. And, if what you need is to see her again… I guess I can help you with that— he offered, regretting it almost instantly.

Castaspella looked at him with an expression of shock that barely hid the shine of hope in her eyes.

—What? How?

Reluctant, but determined to carry on if that would help her, he explained —Remember Glimmer mentioned Catra had brought back the pieces of the mask?

—But the girls only have that left of her, and Shadow Weaver raised them, she was like their mother, even if a cruel one— Castaspella countered. —They wouldn't want anyone tampering with it.

—Hey, trust me, the mask will be fine. It's just to summon her. We need something uniquely hers and that's all there is left— he assured her. —And they would probably like to see her again, no?

—Well… maybe. But they aren't on Etheria now, remember? Glimmer has been telling us of their current mission in space.

He thought for a moment before asking —Didn't she also say that Bow manages communications with them? We could ask him to let us speak with the girls.

Hours later, both of them were patiently waiting for Bow to establish a clear connection channel with the ship, accompanied by Glimmer who was intrigued with their request.

—Alright, this should… do— Bow sentenced, and a moment later Catra appeared on the screen.

—Hey, Arrow boy, we just reported yesterday— was the first they heard, Catra's voice clearly annoyed, and her expression showing mild anger.

—Ignore her, Bow— Adora's voice rang out of the screen. —What happened?

—Well, Micah and Castaspella wanted to talk with you two, and it seems like they can't wait — he explained, obviously confused.

—Seriously? Why?— Catra asked, looking perplexed at them.

Still out of the screen, Adora asked —Of course, what can we help you with, your majesties?

Castaspella took some steps forward to answer —We know you kept the remains of Shadow Weaver's mask. We need to borrow them.

—What!? No!— Catra exclaimed immediately.

—Catra, wait— Adora interrupted. —Why do you need it?

—No, no! Forget it! I'm not letting them near the mask!— Catra insisted.

—Please, I'm begging you— Castaspella quickly said. Her expression showed the storm of emotions within her. —I wouldn't ask for it but… Please, I won't let anything happen to it— she promised.

—Catra, let me speak with her— Adora asked.

—No, no. No way— she refused.

—I just want to know what they want to do with it— she insisted. Catra huffed but gave in and moved away from the screen to let them see Adora still piloting the ship as she asked — What are you planning to do with the mask?

Castaspella looked away with embarrassment and answered —I… I need to speak with her again, and Micah offered to help me summon her.

Glimmer and Bow exchanged a surprised look before looking between her and Micah in the same way, and through the screen, it could be seen that Adora and Catra did the same.

Catra was the first to break the silence, asking with absolute annoyance, —Sparkles, is this some weird plan of your dad to get rid of all that remains from her!?

—Catra!— Adora told her off, but seemed to share her concern. She looked back at them and said —We saw her release all her power and vanish along with a gigantic beast. There's no way anything from her remains. What makes you think you could summon her?

This time, Micah spoke up, even if it seemed like he'd rather pass unnoticed.

—Normally, it wouldn't be possible. But, when she did the Spell of Obtainment, it bound a fraction of herself to the magic on the center of Etheria. When she was corrupted, part of that

parasitic magic returned to the core taking maybe half of her life force, if not more. That's also why she became weaker when she had no more power to absorb.

Adora's expression changed almost instantly. She looked back at Castaspella and noticed something unexpected which made her convince Catra.

—Please, trust my judgment. It's gonna be alright— she told her. —And we can then go to see her when we're back.

—Who wants to see the old woman?— she retorted.

—You were crying for her just yesterday!

—Shut it!

Glimmer had to cover a giggle and Bow rolled his eyes, already tired of witnessing their squabbles.

—Just tell them where it is— Adora told her.

—Fine. But you better make that spell work.

Two days later, Micah and Castaspella were at the Lunarium once again, setting everything up to begin the summoning as soon as the eclipse of the three moons began. He was busy drawing the spell on the ground around the small stone pool in the center while his sister, without anything to do, kept nervously walking back and forth.

—Please relax, will you? I don't have to explain why you need to be calm to do this, right?

Castaspella halted and looked at him. She had just realized something and suddenly needed to ask him about it.

—How did you know, the other day, that I was… Thinking about her?

Micah looked up, his expression grim, and replied —You've always known it happened here. And I was told here… she attacked you all with some shadow spell.

Castaspella held back a giggle.

—I can't believe your logic was "she totally kicked her ass here, *of course* she must be thinking about her"— she said with harsh sarcasm.

—Eh… Sis, are you *sure* you're okay?

—I- That was- I mean, yes, I'm fine. That was just… A slip of the tongue— she stammered as she realized what she had said.

Micah couldn't hold his laughter and had to stop drawing the spell before he ruined it.

When he calmed down, he commented —I did sound like that, didn't I?

She didn't answer but smiled a bit, finding it a little funny too. She then patiently watched as he finished; feeling now more relaxed, she was ready to begin as soon as he said. Once the last line was drawn, Micah collected all the books he was using as reference and placed them outside the area of the spell, then took the pieces of the mask and let them sink into the water of the stone pool.

—Micah… What if this doesn't work? The eclipse is so short…— Castaspella doubted.

—We'll try next month then— he gently replied. —Now, get ready, it will begin in a moment.

Slowly, second by second, the three moons began aligning, and the atmosphere got notoriously more energetic than before. They watched the moons through the oculus and, as soon as their power poured into the Lunarium, Micah and Castaspella initiated the spell.

The Summoning - Part 2

Chapter Summary

With everything they need, the moons aligned, and the spell drawn, the siblings summon the spirit of Shadow Weaver from the depths of Etheria. But the result could be a little more than they gambled for, and it might be time to accept honesty as the best politic; yet truth and teasing sometimes are a bit hard to tell apart.

»With fake innocence, she said —I thought you hated me.
»—Some things change— she muttered.
»Shadow Weaver grabbed her chin to tilt it up as she taunted —You're so cute when you don't want to admit things aloud, you know? Go on, just say it.

Chapter Notes

Enter Shadow Weaver

The lines of the seal Micah drew light up, so do their hands, and with a few movements, they both draw a smaller version of the same spell in the air above the small stone pool between them. Once complete, they move it down until the pieces of the mask underwater start glowing too.

Castaspella's heart skipped a beat when a black shadow began to swirl on the surface of the pool, leaked out and, similar to when Shadow Weaver had attacked Mystacor, a tall figure emerged and rose in front of them. However, this time something was different; this wasn't a shadow spy, this wasn't even a threatening entity, it seemed restrained by the magic of the eclipse, and soon the shadow changed from a dark color to a cyan glow.

Her fear was slowly overwhelmed by a strange form of hope the Head Sorceress refused to acknowledge and she stared at the figure as it took a clearer form. Moments before the eclipse finished, Shadow Weaver opened her eyes to find herself floating above the stone pool in which her broken mask kept glowing. She observed the magical body in which she had been summoned and began laughing loudly. She didn't notice either Micah nor Castaspella staring as she carefully made her way down to the ground; one of her hands instinctively reached for her face as, even after death, she felt uncomfortable without her mask. And the moment the eclipse ended, all the glowing faded and she looked, though opaque, almost as if she was alive again.

—I certainly never expected to be summoned after dying— she said, only to be suddenly interrupted by a hug. Like the last time, she froze in place, and once again, she heard Castaspella murmuring an apology. She only managed to utter —This… wasn't expected either. Why are you hugging me again?

—*Again*!?

Micah's indignant cry echoed through the Lunarium.

—What exactly is happening here?— she finally asked, unable to hide her astonishment as she realized *he* had summoned her too.

Castaspella let go of her and took a few steps back, clearly ashamed.

—I… I'm sorry, this must be… a lot. But I just…— she stammered. Suddenly, her attitude changed, instead of ashamed, she now seemed angry. —No. This is… It's your fault! You… how could you!? Every time you always, *always*, survived everything thrown at you, and this time you just had to selflessly give up your life!?— she began rambling, at first stammering, unable to look at anything but her own hands, yet incapable to stop talking. —I get it, you did it for them, you had to, but, ugh! What timing! We finally managed to have *one* decent conversation, and the next thing you do is vanish into thin air, leaving only that broken mask. I just can't believe it! Was it on purpose!? With all the help you could have provided us now that we aren't at each other's neck… But no, you took it to the extreme of suddenly having such pure intentions you willingly gave up your life!—. She was talking quickly, oblivious to the disbelief in Micah's stare. Shadow Weaver patiently heard her nonsensical verbiage and, from time to time, looked back at Micah to see if his reactions changed. —…Do you *really* expect me to believe you couldn't obliterate that beast without destroying yourself in the process!? As if!

—Castaspella— she interrupted her, finally halting her endless rant. —Will this take any longer? Or are you finally done expressing your frustration?

She opened her mouth to reply but shame kept her silent.

—What *was* that?— Micah asked, stunned.

—I suppose you have too many mixed emotions, don't you, Castaspella? I'm surprised by how much my death affected you, enough that you managed to convince Micah to summon me. How interesting— Shadow Weaver said, mostly trying to provoke her.

—Actually—, Castaspella looked away, —This was *his* idea.

—It… was?

Micah refused to meet her bewildered gaze at first but anger got the best of him and he furiously stated —Don't get any wrong ideas. I just want you to undo whatever charm you've cast on her.

—You think I used *magic* on her?— she asked, incredulous. Castaspella hadn't managed to speak again but was about to ask the same, her indignation clear on her expression. —Please, Micah. I had no need at all.

—How else would you explain… That!? She… She *hugged* you!— he yelled.

—You seriously think she bewitched me!? I can't believe *you* deceived me— Castaspella finally retorted. —You said you wanted to *help me*!

—As much as I enjoy your bickering, I'd rather you get to the point. Why was I summoned?

Shadow Weaver's severe tone kept them from further arguing, they just stared at each other angrily without speaking for a moment. Until Castaspella noticed the sorceress approaching her and composed herself to speak again.

—I have some things to discuss with you— she began, addressing Shadow Weaver. Then, she looked at her brother and asked him —Would you *please* let us speak privately, Micah.

He wanted to refuse, but it was obvious he angered her, so he had no right to make demands and now had to comply.

—Fine. But I will be at the door, if I hear anything I won't hesitate to intervene— he declared before finally walking away.

Castaspella looked as he walked away and once she saw him out she let out a sigh.

—I didn't want to admit it but, ah… You left me thinking, alright? When we last talked, you… Let's just say you told me exactly what I needed to hear, even if it seems odd. You were right, I lacked confidence but, if it hadn't been you who told me that, I would have *never* trusted myself to help the princesses or Glimmer to fight the Horde. It was… I hadn't fought alongside them before, and I just *know* I would've hesitated if it wasn't for that conversation. I was… Looking forward to talking with you again— she admitted.

Shadow Weaver walked closer as she replied —Is that so? Well, you seemed determined to surprise me today. Any other unbelievable confessions to make?—. The sorceress didn't waste a moment before teasing Castaspella. With fake innocence, she said —I thought you hated me.

—Some things change— she muttered.

Shadow Weaver grabbed her chin to tilt it up as she taunted —You're so cute when you don't want to admit things aloud, you know? Go on, just say it.

—Oh, stop your teasing. I'm serious— Castaspella pushed her away gently, as soon as she was out of her shock. —Look, I know how this must sound but… I just *need* you to be here. When I said this was Micah's idea… Well, it was. He realized I missed you, I didn't want to admit it, and yet… It was obvious for him—. Castaspella turned around as she explained —He convinced me this would let me have closure, go on… Hah! How am I supposed to "go on" if my confidence depends… Depends on your approval?

—“Someone is being unusually honest today”, my turn to say it— Shadow Weaver teased her, earning a sincere laugh from Castaspella. —Now, seriously. Do you still feel “too young” for the position you hold?— she asked, approaching the Head Sorceress again. Something in her unmasked expression sent chills down her spine, and Castaspella couldn't help taking one step back for each Shadow Weaver took forward. —Do you need me to tell you you're more powerful than you believe?— she teased. One of her arms wrapped around her waist but Castaspella kept backtracking. —Do you want me to tell you your power equals mine? Isn't that arrogant of you?

That moment, Shadow Weaver’s arm suddenly lost density, Castaspella almost fell back but managed to stay on her foot. Then they both noticed she had walked out of the spell’s area.

—You're… confined to the inside of the spell— she noticed. —It’s independent of the eclipse, but you only retain density within it. I can't believe the strength it has.

—As expected from a spell cast by Micah— the sorceress commented as if it were obvious.

—It was the both of us— Castaspella corrected her, mildly annoyed.

Shadow Weaver let out a smirk and extended a hand at her, inviting.

—Well, said. You're not hopeless.

Even if she kept annoying her, Castaspella walked back into the area and accepted her hand. It was clear Shadow Weaver wanted her to say something, so she took a deep breath and carefully chose her words.

—I am… afraid.

—Again.

—Yes, *again*—. Castaspella rolled her eyes but let herself smirk as an answer. —I am afraid that I'm… I'm not half the tutor you were— she finally admitted, letting go of the sorceress’s hand and wrapping her arms around herself.

Shadow Weaver dropped the mockery. With genuine concern, she approached her and placed a hand on her shoulder.

—What makes you say that, Cas?

Castaspella closed her eyes and sighed deeply.

—It’s a fact. I'm not… This isn't self-loathing, okay? It's the one truth no one in Mystacor wants to admit yet can't deny— she replied with absolute seriousness.

—Really? How quaint.

—You're enjoying this too much— she rebuked her.

Instead of teasing further or even laughing, Shadow Weaver moved her hand to set it on Castaspella's right cheek and gently made her face her.

—You feel insecure and decided to seek me out despite the implications. Don't think I don't appreciate it— she began, serious as ever. —So, why don't you just leave this spell active? If you need advice, just come to me. I'd be more than glad to assist you. I can stay here all the time you need, I don't have *anything* to do now, you know?

Castaspella held a giggle and looked away.

—I was already planning to leave it active at least until Adora and Catra are back— she replied. Shadow Weaver seemed surprised again. —Oh, right. I forgot to tell you… Your mask was recovered by Catra. We had to convince them to lend it to us, but the possibility of seeing you again seemed to persuade them. It's clear Adora is still fond of you despite all and, she may not admit it, but even Catra misses you.

Shadow Weaver turned around. She didn't want Castaspella to see how much that meant for her. She only looked back when she heard the Heard Sorceress footsteps as she walked away.

—Thank you— she pronounced.

—Likewise— Castaspella replied, without looking back.

The Crystal of Arxia

Chapter Summary

Back from their mission in space, Catra and Adora finally visit their nightmare and unexpected savior, the woman who raised them and put them through hell.

Does Shadow Weaver now find honesty to be harmless as she's no longer alive or has death softened her heart?
»—Don’t do this— Catra interrupted, almost like a plea. —I can’t- I won’t believe it if you say you always loved us.
»—I won’t. But I can, if not justify my behavior, at least explain myself— she offered.

But not everyone can see this side of her. Though it may seem strange or unlikely, others will blame her if the earth trembles, even if she can't actually touch anything outside the small area of the summoning spell. Too many years ago, after being corrupted, she claimed Mystacor didn't deserve her help, but presently, she won't hesitate to provide it. Maybe she is now a bit too willing to help Castaspella to remember her old promises.

Around three weeks had passed and everything in Mystacor seemed to be running rather smoothly. It was early in the morning but Castaspella was already working; for the past few months she had been reviewing plenty of old documents, investigations mostly, and there was one she had recently found which may be important for Mystacor. However, it seemed to be theoretical and part of it had become unreadable, but it was clearly signed by *Light Spinner*, so she planned to take it to Shadow Weaver that same day.

A knock on the door distracted her from the old scroll and she went to open the door.

—Oh, girls! You’re here!— she welcomed, seeing it was Glimmer, Adora, and Catra. —I’ll presume you don’t want to waste time, so let’s get going— she suggested, noticing Catra already looked annoyed.

As she walked them to the Lunarium, she couldn’t help giving Glimmer and Adora a hug, yet she didn’t even try with Catra, sure she’d earn a scratch. She explained to them how the spell worked, that within the area Shadow Weaver was as real as everything in their world, and that it seemed she no longer had magic. Which made it all the more surprising when they walked in and found the sorceress comfortably sitting on a sofa that was *not* given to her by anyone in Mystacor.

—Well, look who came to visit this old woman— she said with a smirk.

Catra and Adora kept silent, unable to speak as they could feel a lump on their throats and their tears about to fall. Meanwhile, Glimmer realized what was out of place and subtly

looked at her aunt, who was clearly indignant.

—How come you have a sofa now?— she questioned her, taking some steps forward.

—Am I not allowed?— Shadow Weaver asked with fake innocence.

—Oh, come on! Don't start with that. If you wanted a sofa, cushions, a damned book to read, you could have *asked* for it!— she retorted. —I mean, how is it possible that you *can* do magic and haven't told us!?

—Relax, Cas, you'll get wrinkles— she teased her, which made Castaspella roll her eyes. —It's not magic like you think. But I believe we should discuss it later, no? I have visits.

—You better remember— she replied in a lower tone, only for her to hear. Then, she turned around and noticed the girls were still shocked. —Come on now, girls. It's perfectly safe— she assured them with a gentle tone. They slowly walked closer, hesitant to enter the area of the spell. —You don't need to enter, if you feel safer outside where she can't touch you, it's fine. But have no worries, and remember you can always walk away whenever you want.

—Th-thank you, your majesty— Adora stammered.

—Now, we'll leave you three to talk, see you later.

As the Head Sorceress and Glimmer left the room, the girls stared at Shadow Weaver, still overwhelmed. She stood up and made eye contact for a second before embarrassment overtook her. However, before she could move, Adora rushed to hug her; it took Shadow Weaver a moment to react and, at least, caress her hair.

—I'm glad to see you're still in one piece, Adora— she finally said, making a conscious effort not to speak as she usually did to her; she felt like it would only awaken their hatred for her.

—You still favor her? Good to know death hasn't changed you— Catra said mockingly, her arms crossed in front of her chest.

—Drop the facade, Catra— Shadow Weaver told her good-naturedly. —I was told *you* recovered my mask, and if you still hated me, you wouldn't be here.

Adora let go of the sorceress and went to grab Catra's arm to pull her closer.

—Less taunting, more hugging— she said, before pulling them both for another hug, more awkward this time.

—Wait… ugh— Shadow Weaver grunted.

—Yes, *ugh*— Catra echoed.

—At least now you agree— Adora teased, finally releasing them. She let some tears fall and said —Sorry, but I always wanted to do that.

Both of them looked away from Adora to hide the smile she provoked and mumbled something unintelligible that made her laugh.

—Ah… this feels too strange to be real— Shadow Weaver sighed. —It's almost ironic.

—Why?— Adora asked, genuinely interested.

—It will soon be yet another year since, in this exact place, I became "Shadow Weaver". Remember the discussion about the Spell of Obtainment?—. They both nodded. —I did it here, *we* did it here. It failed, I got completely corrupted and…

—Lost Micah— Adora finished.

—Yes—. She looked away as she continued —It wasn't long before you were brought to the Fright Zone as a baby, Adora, and just a few years later you, Catra.

—Don't do this— Catra interrupted, almost like a plea. —I can't- I won't believe it if you say you always loved us.

—I won't. But I can, if not justify my behavior, at least explain myself— she offered. The girls shared a look and nodded again. —I felt Adora's power the first moment I walked past her, which made me ask Hordak to keep you. Catra, on the other hand, had little special when she arrived, only the fact that she survived years alone before we found her. And yet, she grew to prove me wrong— she began explaining, surprising them. —Actually, had you not shown to be just as capable as Adora, despite not being "powerful" according to my judgment, I wouldn't have tormented you as much— she admitted. Catra seemed confused, so she continued —I told you I saw too much of myself in you, and "not being special" but keeping up with those naturally gifted was the main similarity. The other was the hunger for power but not alone, rather as a consequence of feeling it was a need to be complete. And guess what? We were both wrong and didn't know better until we hit rock bottom.

—Don't tell me falling from Hordak's grace was your "hit rock bottom"— Catra defied her.

—Absolutely not— she replied, so honest it left the girl speechless. —No, no. I still had the same mindset through my time with the Rebellion, it never changed until much later.

—When we went to the Heart— Adora realized.

Shadow Weaver nodded, her expression showing a sorrow the mask would have kept hidden.

—It's ironic to think it was also when I finally knew true power. Good timing, however, or that beast would have killed me and still chase after you— she added, trying to be humorous at the end.

—How?— Catra asked, a mix of disbelief and hope. —How did you suddenly recover your powers and… why did you do it?

—If you're thinking it was for you…—, she began with a severe tone, —Then you're right— she admitted, with a sad smile quite like the last she gave them. She preferred to ignore the effect her statement had on them and looked away as she explained —Let's just say a certain

someone told me that the strength you and your friends manifested out of love for each other wasn't something to be understood but rather accepted. And all I did was deny how much I cared for you two; after losing someone who was to me as my own son, I refused to care for anyone in the same way, but you *were* like daughters to me. I was cruel because I tried to prove myself I didn't actually care for either of you, threw you into danger after danger… And that night I was pushing Adora to use the failsafe because that was something I understood, it *was* the solution and was imperant. But not for you—. She finally looked at Adora in the eyes and said —You had decided to leave your friends behind and continue alone when we went for you; Catra didn't hesitate to try and stall the creature so you could continue; and even though you were poisoned, had no time to lose, you turned around when you were almost there, because, against all logic, your love for Catra gave you the strength to return for her, not to leave her behind—. She paused a moment, looked down, and with a resigned expression, concluded —Only then I realized I never really knew true power, true strength. I realized love wasn't a weakness, even if I had thought so for many years, and as soon as I accepted as much, I simply *felt* it: the burning power within me, the raging desire to keep you both safe, not to save Etheria, not to free the magic, just to make sure you both would survive. And that allowed me to unleash all my power as I had never done before and gave me the strength I needed to let it consume me along with the beast.

At first, she didn't want to look up at them, but she did as soon as she heard them sobbing, thinking she had said something wrong. Catra and Adora were crying silent tears, holding each other's hands as if their lives depended on it, and Shadow Weaver felt the need to retreat. However, Adora caught her wrist to stop her and, this time, it was Catra who suddenly hugged her, a bit angry still, but even sadder.

The sorceress joked about how, at this rate, the hugs would soften her before next year, which fortunately lightened their mood. However, their happiness was short-lived, as a sudden tremor shook all of Mystacor, and before they could wonder what had happened, almost all the council flocked into the place.

In the gardens of Mystacor, not too far from the Lunarium, Glimmer and Castaspella walked side by side while conversing.

—… Auntie, can I ask you about that scroll you were reading when we arrived?— she asked her.

A little surprised that she noticed but considering it would be of her interest, she decided to answer —Well, the past few months I've been reviewing old documents from Mystacor. Erm… Mostly all of… eh, all the investigations and studies that were done by Light Spinner back in her time—. Glimmer refrained from giving her a knowing look which Castaspella had been anticipating. —Before summoning her, I thought we'd have no other chance to access her immense knowledge, you know. Everything was here, maybe incomplete or too difficult to understand but I've been going through those papers to finally understand what Mystacor needs— she explained. —That document particularly called my attention because it's her old investigation about the Crystal of Arxia, and well… Now I understand how she knew so much about it, but there are parts missing, and I'm not entirely sure if my suspicions

are right. So once your friends are done, I'll have to take that scroll to her; that way I'll know if I have to worry or not.

—What could be worrisome about the Crystal?— Glimmer asked.

—I'm only guessing, but she mentions several times that it's a key location in Mystacor and maybe…

Before she could finish, the land beneath their feet quaked violently. Their looks said it all, her fears were correct and they needed answers now. They didn't lose a second, Glimmer teleported with Castaspella back to her room and left her to get the scroll as she teleported directly to the Lunarium.

But the scene that greeted her when she appeared was less than ideal.

—What has she done!?

—This has to be her fault!

—Why is she still here!?

Several council members kept shouting at Shadow Weaver, while Catra and She-ra held them away. Glimmer noticed the sorceress wasn't even trying to defend herself and decided to help the girls.

—You have no right to make such accusations— she declared, calling their attention. All council members looked back at her, some ashamed, some still furious. —The nature of the summoning makes it evident this is *not* her fault.

—How can you be sure!?

—She isn't even under permanent vigilance.

—She knows this place too well, it *has* to be her doing.

Another tremor shook the place, scaring everyone into silence for a moment.

—You all need to stop this madness. This clearly won't stop just by yelling at her— Glimmer insisted.

—We told them so!— Catra roared, her claws out and ready to slash if any of them moved towards them. —But they want to dismiss the spell.

—She has to go!

—The tremors may stop once she vanishes!

—Don't you dare touch that spell!— Castaspella exclaimed, her voice ringing from the door as she had just arrived. —None of you speak another word. You have *no* idea what is going

on— she ordered. —But she does. You vanish her, and Mystacor falls. And I mean that quite literally.

Everyone had to comply and only observed as she walked into the area of the spell. The Head Sorceress handed Shadow Weaver a tattered scroll which she quickly recognized.

—Of course, it had to be the Crystal— she said. —I guess you're not completely doomed, after all. You finally have a competent ruler— she commented, and Castaspella had to look away before anyone noticed her blush.

—Ahem! The document is incomplete, I needed to ask you what we're supposed to do to stabilize the Crystal of Arxia— she clarified.

—The Crystal? From where I took the failsafe?— Adora realized.

—When you did, it was completely drained of energy. And without it, it's been decaying. You're lucky to have survived this long— Shadow Weaver explained, her last comment more of a reproach to the council members. —Luckily, it's pretty much like the force shield you used to have around Mystacor. You won't be able to use the three Moons of Enchantment for this, but it's the exact same principle, it needs monthly recharging.

Castaspella clapped, calling everyone's attention, and ordered —We're doing this now, no time to lose. You heard her, it's just a recharging spell, so all able sorcerers are to be gathered and taken down to the Crystal of Arxia. The ones strong enough for structural-reinforcement spells are to make sure everyone reaches the Crystal safely, and the rest waste no time, look for Micah and begin the recharge with his help—. All council members turned and left the room without questioning her, and she addressed Glimmer and She-ra —I need you two to take all kids in Mystacor to safety, and then go to the Crystal too, it may also need your power to fully heal.

They both left in an instant, and before she could follow, Shadow Weaver commented —It will need far more power than when you recharged the shield, possibly ten times more, and you don't have external help from the eclipse this time.

Castaspella turned and with a confident smile answered —I'm sure with all the sorcerers, Micah, Glimmer, and myself, it will be enough—. She then looked at Catra and told her —Better stay here to keep guard.

—You expect her to flee or something?

—More like I fear someone might take advantage of the confusion.

Catra couldn't even answer as the Head Sorceress left, and when she looked back at Shadow Weaver, her expression revealed a similar astonishment.

The Three Moons of Enchantment - Part 1

Chapter Summary

Repercussions from the Crystal of Arxia's decaying keep the Sorcerers Guild busy and spark doubts within the council. But nothing seems to stop Castaspella who, bolder than ever, wants Shadow Weaver to teach again.

»At the end of the meeting, she had announced her intention of asking Shadow Weaver to tutor again; the council members were almost evenly divided between considering it a terrible or the best idea, and Micah utterly disagreed with his sister. He was so absolutely sure she would never agree, he simply challenged Castaspella to try, assuring no one would convince her to teach again.
»It was already very late that night, but she was determined to prove Micah wrong and arrived at the Lunarium decided to talk Shadow Weaver into tutoring once more.

Chapter Notes

This was intended to be a single chapter but ended up being SO LONG I spent 10' considering where to cut it...

You're gonna hate me for my decision but I *really* had no better option than the cliff-hanger, please don't kill me.

Hours after the tremors, half the sorcerers in Mystacor are working on reparations in several buildings that suffered severe damage with the quakes, and the others rest while they can. Castaspella ordered them to take turns repairing all structures so they would quickly be safe again and the children evacuated from Mystacor can return as soon as possible. However, personally inspecting every building after spending so much energy with the recharge of the Crystal of Arxia has left her exhausted, and Glimmer decided it would be better if she accompanied her back to the Lunarium.

—No need to worry anymore, Auntie. The reparations seem to be going fine, and from now on the recharges will be just like when you kept up the shield. I’m sure there won’t be any more crises to deal with any time soon— Glimmer told her, with a little of humor, trying to get her to relax.

—We barely managed to avoid a real tragedy; another tremor and some of the buildings would have crumbled down completely— Castaspella answered with a pained expression.

—But they didn't.

—Because, by mere chance, I had been investigating the matter beforehand and was ready to act. Almost too convenient if you ask me— she retorted.

Glimmer noticed something in her expression and carefully asked —You don't think the council members are right, do you? It can't possibly have been her!

—I know, I… think I know. Ugh— her answer was too quick at first, which made her hesitate even more. —How do I know I'm not biased? Perhaps I just *don't want* to believe it was Shadow Weaver's doing. I'd like to think it's just that I trust her, but maybe it's not even that — she let out.

—What do you mean?

—Do I actually trust her, or do I think I *have to* trust her or… or admit defeat.

Glimmer stared at her. She had been suspecting for a while *what* was confusing Castaspella so much, but now it seemed to be a rather deep subject.

—Aunt Casta, if you fear she hasn't changed at all but it's your feelings that won't let you accept that, or that you deceive yourself about her true intentions… Maybe you just need to talk with the people who know her and can tell you whether that's true or not.

The Head Sorceress took a deep breath and stopped a moment to hug her niece, which only worried Glimmer more.

—Thank you… I suppose you're right— she admitted, before reaching the Lunarium.

Both of them calmly entered the place, finding Adora already there and, unsurprisingly, Catra and Shadow Weaver arguing.

—…So you don't even care!? Seriously!?— the girl yelled.

—Or *you* care too much— the sorceress replied with absolute carelessness. As soon as she noticed Glimmer and Castaspella had arrived, she simply abandoned the argument and turned to address the Head Sorceress. —I see you're back already. Crises averted, I presume. So let me congratulate you for handling everything with so much confidence, even when I questioned your capacity to recharge the Crystal.

Castaspella was sure it was just teasing and yet couldn't help smiling, and even blushing, at a literal compliment from her.

—Now you're just being mean, you know?— she replied, with a knowing expression and her arms crossed in front of her chest.

Shadow Weaver smirked and had to make an effort to hold back a laugh.

—Clever indeed, has Adora given you pointers?

—No need, the lack of mask helps a lot— she taunted, feeling suddenly bold.

To everyone's surprise, if Castaspella's teasing wasn't already shocking, Shadow Weaver was unable to hide her ashamed reaction and left everyone speechless for a moment.

—I'll take it back. Death *definitely* changed you— Catra commented, breaking the tense silence before it could stretch any longer.

—Well— Glimmer giggled nervously. —I just came to properly thank you for the help and to take these two back. If you're ready…

—No wait, I'm sure she won't mention it so *I'll* tell you— Catra addressed Castaspella.

—I said there's no need— Shadow Weaver interrupted.

—Oh, I remember, but now I know why you're being so stubborn about it, which means I *have* to let her know— she insisted defiantly. Taking a few steps towards Castaspella, she began —It's obvious you care, or you wouldn't have asked me to guard her, so listen carefully: someone here, possibly from your council, sent some kind of magical imp or whatever to try and dismiss the spell—. She crossed her arms, standing around a meter away from her. —Normally it wouldn't matter because whatever magic she can still do should have been enough to keep that thing away but for *some reason*, she seems unwilling to keep herself safe. It's up to you that whoever wants her gone can't succeed.

The girl's irritation was enough for Castaspella to picture what had happened and her expression darkened.

—Thank you, I'll stay alert— she assured Catra.

Adora seemed to want to express her concern but Glimmer gestured to her not to speak and the girls farewelled, obviously intending to discuss the matter without them knowing. Left alone, the Head Sorceress stared at Shadow Weaver who refused to look back.

—I have nothing to say— the sorceress finally said.

—Actually, you do. You promised me an explanation, remember?

—Ah, that. I thought you wondered if I had anything to do with the Crystal's decay.

—Drop it, I will discuss that with those who know you; I'm clearly *not* objective enough to question you about that— Castaspella replied, rolling her eyes, as she walked into the area of the spell.

Shadow Weaver turned around and, almost as if she had teleported, she was suddenly behind the Head Sorceress, hands on her waist and mouth close to her left ear.

—Not objective enough?— she whispered.

—But not stupid. Don't you dare try to deflect anymore— Castaspella insisted, ignoring the stream of goosebumps traveling her body. —Do you have magic still? Or what is it?

—All business and no fun? Have it your way. But I wasn't deflecting, I plan to explain you… after I demonstrate— Shadow Weaver whispered again, with her usual severe tone, tightening her grip on her. —Stay very still.

Castaspella slightly turned her head to face her and swallowed hard; it felt as if an electric current enveloped them, her focus completely overtaken by the sorceress no matter how hard she tried to look elsewhere. But when Shadow Weaver looked back at her, she forced herself to look away and noticed everything around her had changed. She was sure they hadn't left the Lunarium, they couldn't even have left the area of the spell for she could still feel the sorceress's hands on her.

—What is this? Looks like… that magical groove in the Whispering Woods— Castaspella sighed.

—Good to know you remember it— Shadow Weaver teased. —This isn't sorcery. It's an illusion. One I can interact with— she explained, as one of her hands released her to grab the glowing dust floating near them. —I'm no longer here, remember? The body into which you and Micah summoned me is purely made of magic. It's far stronger than an illusion solely because of the part of me that was invoked to inhabit it. But that means anything created from the same type of magical energy can interact with me as if it was real too— she explained.

—Fascinating— she let out. —So that sofa isn't even there, you just created an illusion only you can use— Castaspella reflected.

—If you're asking whether you can sit on it or not, then no you can't— Shadow Weaver tantalized. —But I guess you could sit on my lap while I'm seated on it and that would count as sitting on the illusionary sofa.

Castaspella let out a hearty laugh that surprised the sorceress and even made her blush. She expected any other reaction, maybe annoyance or indignation even, but never that. It seemed like the Head Sorceress was enjoying herself.

—Why didn't you say anything before?— she asked her, once she had calmed down.

Shadow Weaver dismissed the illusion, electing to ignore what she felt a moment ago, and everything around them returned to normal.

—I would never say I can do something if I haven't perfected my technique, which I consider to only have achieved this morning— she answered, walking away from Castaspella.

With genuine concern, Castaspella asked —Aren't you being a bit too hard on yourself?

—Nonsense. There's hardly anything better to do with my time, why not use it to perfect the only thing I can do now?— she asked back, her tone almost cheerful.

The Head Sorceress smiled a moment before being interrupted by a yawn. It was evident she was completely drained of energy and should have gone to sleep already, but Shadow Weaver wouldn't let herself wonder why she didn't wait until the next day to go and speak with her.

During the next week, Castaspella kept examining the structural integrity of Mystacor on a daily basis and called council meetings twice. At the first one, they had discussed the issue of the Crystal of Arxia decaying; Castaspella explained she had been suspecting something like that would happen and it was to be considered a happy coincidence as time was of the essence to avoid irremediable damage. Glimmer had supported her and vouched for Shadow Weaver's innocence, but because the council, just as Castaspella herself, questioned their impartiality, both Adora and Catra were invited to a second reunion to testify about the sorceress behavior. During that second meeting, the girls explained that their experience with Shadow Weaver evidenced she could be trusted now; both admitted she's not exactly helping out of goodness, but also reminded them that she always had a reason for everything she did, and destroying Mystacor would achieve nothing.

However, when questioned about what was her reason to be helping, they both hesitated for a moment; they had been talking about it and agreed with Glimmer that there was *definitely* something between those two, but they would never expose Castaspella like that. Glimmer suggested it may be that she's still a tutor at heart, and being asked for guidance she'd always answer. She told them about the time she taught She-Ra how to heal; it had been the one thing to save her as she agonized, and they could also consider that her assistance is the only reason why she's still summoned.

Now Castaspella was on her way to the Lunarium. At the end of the meeting, she had announced her intention of asking Shadow Weaver to tutor again; the council members were almost evenly divided between considering it a terrible or the best idea, and Micah utterly disagreed with his sister. He was so absolutely sure she would never agree, he simply challenged Castaspella to try, assuring no one would convince her to teach again.

It was already very late that night, but she was determined to prove Micah wrong and arrived at the Lunarium decided to talk Shadow Weaver into tutoring once more. However, an unexpected scene made her stop in her tracks and almost refrain from breathing too loudly. She found her *dancing*.

The Three Moons of Enchantment - Part 2

Chapter Summary

> Castaspella may have entered dangerous grounds, worse than she can even imagine, putting herself in a *very* awkward position with her brother. Things are bound to get nasty unless Micah accepts his sister can handle herself, even when treading with a dark sorceress like Shadow Weaver.
>
> »—You're giving off the same energy as the spell— Shadow Weaver sentenced. —This… can't be…
> »—The eclipse…— Castaspella realized, but couldn't say anything else before Micah interrupted.
> »—Just *what* have you two done?— he angrily questioned. —Answer now.
> »—It was an accident, Micah. I arrived here and she was performing that choreography we learn for the Guild dances… How could we have known it had any magical properties? It's just a dance!— Castaspella explained, genuinely surprised.
> »—Why do I think *she* knew exactly what she was doing?— he accused the sorceress, yet again.

The sorceress seemed to be on a world of her own, letting the light of the Three Moons of Enchantment wash over her, ever closer to aligning once again. Under the cloak of night and so gently illuminated by the moonlight, no one would have believed it was Shadow Weaver the one dancing as if some invisible magical current guided her around.

Castaspella recognized the dance and couldn't believe how flawlessly executed it was. She hadn't seen someone dance like that in years, if ever. So, when the sorceress noticed her staring, there was no mistaking her admiration.

—Enjoying the show, Cas?— she teased the Head Sorceress as she came to a stop.

Castaspella mentally thanked the darkness of the night for hiding her furious blush and focused on answering in a similar manner.

—I didn't take you for someone who knew how to dance.

Shadow Weaver rolled her eyes a bit as she said —It's not like I had a choice back then, the dance was mandatory—. Looking directly into her eyes, almost challenging her, she continued —So I improved my form until it was just as perfect as my casting. Care for a demonstration?

Castaspella was about to complain about her constantly gloating over her perfectionism, but the moment Shadow Weaver extended a hand at her offering to dance, she simply lost her

speech. Before she could even think about it, she had walked up to her and accepted her hand. Offering no resistance, she followed her moves; the Head Sorceress was always the one who organized the dances of the Guild, but she herself had never even attempted to dance, despite knowing the steps. And she could never have guessed it would be such a mesmerizing experience.

The air around them suddenly buzzed with energy, the eclipse had begun, and the rise in magical power was almost intoxicating, sufficient for Castaspella to feel it coursing through her veins, almost burning her insides. The only thing keeping her focused, enough to let the magic flow within her without hurting her, was Shadow Weaver's intense stare as they slid across the floor, delicately spinning to the right, then to the left; they circled the whole area of the spell several times before the eclipse ended.

—You weren't exaggerating. "Perfect" is pretty much the only way to describe how this feels. I… I never thought such a simple dance could be so… *incredible*— Castaspella expressed, unable to find the right words.

As the eclipse ended, the magical energy around them calmed down and the Head Sorceress slowly recovered her senses, the cloud in her mind dissipated, and suddenly she was too conscious of their proximity. When she blushed and shyly looked away, Shadow Weaver laughed and held her firmly.

—Are you trying to escape?

—Should I?

She couldn't look back at her but refused to stay silent, and it only amused the sorceress even more. She had her exactly where she wanted her, and she would let her go. Gently, she released Castaspella and walked backward as she wished her good night.

Only the next morning, as she recalled that dream-like dance, did she realize she had forgotten the *only* thing she was supposed to do. If Micah ever knew, he'd be furious, she was sure. So she quickly ate her breakfast and rushed to the Lunarium.

Just as she arrived, coincidentally, her brother appeared from another corridor, seemingly looking for her.

—Just the person I wanted to see— he exclaimed, addressing her.

—Good morning, Micah. Looking for me?— she asked with fake innocence.

—That's right. I'm curious whether you managed to convince Shadow Weaver of your *idea* — he replied imitating her tone.

—I'm on my way to do so— she affirmed, as she renewed her walk.

—Is that so? Or are you going to try again?— he taunted, trying not to sound too accusing. Her confused expression made him add —I happened to see you walk out from here

extremely late yesterday, Sis.

They had just entered the building but were still far enough that Shadow Weaver wouldn't hear them.

—Fine, yes. I came last night to ask her, but I ended up forgetting about it.

—How did you…

Castaspella knew she couldn't answer him and simply walked away without letting him finish. As she reached the area of the spell, Shadow Weaver looked up and greeted her with a smirk.

—Back so soon? What's the problem this time?

—Oh! There's plenty of problems but none worth troubling you, *yet*— Castaspella answered. Micah stayed a few steps behind her and listened carefully; there was something in their extremely friendly interaction that simply put him on edge every time. Mustering her confidence, and wishing to prove her brother wrong right on his face, she added —I have a proposal for you.

—Flattering— Shadow Weaver mocked her. —But won't you kneel first?

—What!?— she exclaimed, right before realization hit. —Oh! You shameless witch! Shut up and listen!— she yelled at her light-heartedly, feeling her face red and purposely ignoring Micah's stillness behind her. —I'm being serious, alright? I'd like you to consider tutoring again.

Shadow Weaver dropped the mocking and solemnly contemplated it.

—Tutoring? Really? I'm sure Micah has *a lot* to say against that.

—It's not *his* decision, it's the council's, and at least half the members like the idea. But only if you want to teach again— Castaspella quickly explained.

—I have more than just "a lot" to say about you. Including the fact that your "tutoring" can hardly be distinguished from your manipulation— Micah answered, ignoring his sister.

—You think I manipulated you? Didn't you insist you were up to the task, and that you would do *anything*?— she evoked, slowly stepping towards him.

—I was a kid, full of energy, impatient, you *saw* that and used it to have me willingly help you— he retorted.

—On the contrary, dear Micah. I wouldn't have dreamed of finally trying the Spell of Obtainment if you hadn't been so *so* willing to help me— she assured him. —My mistake was allowing your enthusiasm to grow enough that I'd be unable to resist the chance. The moment you said you'd do *anything* was the moment I no longer thought about risks because I saw the only opportunity I could possibly have.

She was now standing proudly before him, her full height almost the same as his, and yet she seemed virtually taller.

—You just tell yourself a lot of complicated lies until they become your truth, don't you?— he accused her, crossing his arms in front of his chest, instinctively needing to protect himself.

—It's a shame you still refuse to see the truth. It seemed to help Adora and Catra so much— she replied, cupping his face with one hand, from which he immediately withdrew.

—Alright, stop it, you two— Castaspella interrupted, mildly annoyed, placing her hands on her hips.

Shadow Weaver looked at her with a smirk and asked —Don't tell me you're jealous?

—Cut it. You're doing this on purpose to annoy him— she replied with absolute severity.

—See, Micah? Your sister is too clever to fall for my traps— she commented, as she turned around walking back to her sofa. —I'll consider your offer.

—Seriously!?— Micah exclaimed.

Shadow Weaver stopped and Castaspella held back a triumphant smirk. But she couldn't enjoy her victory even for a second before the sorceress turned around and renewed her taunting.

—*Poor sweet Micah*. Does it hurt to realize you don't know me enough?

—You only accept because you *know* I disagree— he argued.

—No, I am *considering* it because it's the least I owe her.

—So what? Are you trying to put my own sister against me?

—There's no need for me to manipulate either of you into fighting, you're already doing enough on your own. Can't you see how your stubbornness keeps annoying her? Don't you ever ask Cas for her opinion?— she insisted, her tone a mix of smugness and teasing.

—I am *right here*!— Castaspella finally interrupted. —But as you're so determined to argue as if I weren't here listening, I'll just take my leave— she sentenced while turning around, and began walking away.

—Wait, Cas— Shadow Weaver called out, going after her.

The Head Sorceress ignored her, knowing she can follow but not stop her once she's out of the spell, and yet, she soon felt the sorceress's hand on her shoulder.

—I couldn't help it, but you know I wasn't trying to hurt you.

Her tone was absolutely sincere, yet Castaspella couldn't let it pass and replied —Well you did. You couldn't control your obsession with my brother enough to remember my presence in the room. It's basic respect.

Shadow Weaver held her shoulders and insisted —I *wasn't* ignoring you.

Castaspella closed her eyes; it felt, once again, as if her bias clouded her judgment, and she needed to focus. However, before she could say anything, Micah spoke up with such indignation it called both women's attention.

—What *exactly* have you done!?

—What are you talking about?— Shadow Weaver questioned. But he didn't need to answer, they both looked down at the same time and realized they were a few meters outside the area of the spell. —How… can this be?

—Are you doing this?— Castaspella asked.

—I thought I had caught you before you could leave the spell. I didn't… Wait…

—What?

—You're giving off the same energy as the spell— Shadow Weaver sentenced. —This… can't be…

—The eclipse…— Castaspella realized, but couldn't say anything else before Micah interrupted.

—Just *what* have you two done?— he angrily questioned. —Answer now.

—I suppose that old dance was *actually* magical. Dancing around the spell must have linked it to you... or even replicated it within you, the only solid body— Shadow Weaver reflected.

—What!? Why would you two do some magical dance!?— Micah asked, indignant but trying not to shout.

—It was an accident, Micah. I arrived here and she was performing that choreography we learn for the Guild dances… How could we have known it had any magical properties? It's just a dance!— Castaspella explained, genuinely surprised.

—Why do I think *she* knew exactly what she was doing?— he accused the sorceress, yet again.

—You think I did it on purpose!? I wasn't even expecting her to show up!— Shadow Weaver began.

—So it was simply a *coincidence* that you chose last night to dance!? Out of boredom!?— he insisted with a more sarcastic tone.

—If you ask it like that I suppose you're aware what day it was yesterday— she retorted.

Castaspella thought for a moment before realizing —The moon alignment… Not just any but…

—Yes. Yesterday marked yet another year since I attempted that spell— she admitted. Then she addressed Micah, with an expression full of sorrow, —Another year since I lost you.

—Don't tell me it still pains you— Micah defied her, skeptical.

—Even if I hate to admit it, it *is* painful.

—Only because it was a "failure" you can't accept.

Shadow Weaver's expression made it clear he wasn't wrong, and Castaspella felt the need to intervene.

—That's enough— she said, firmly but with a gentle tone. —It's done now, so I guess around me it will be like within the spell. But that doesn't mean you can follow me around— she added.

—Wait, has she been leaving the Lunarium?— Micah asked, suddenly understanding.

—Nothing stops her, why wouldn't she?— Castaspella asked him.

—Are you out of your mind, Casta!?

—She is incorporeal, literally can't touch or affect *anything* outside the spell. How could she possibly pose a threat!?— she pointed out, clearly losing her patience.

—Well, now she can— he retorted.

—Only around me; I already assumed responsibility for anything she might do, what's the difference?

Micah only huffed and gave in, but insisted this changed things and had to be informed to the council. Shadow Weaver subtly returned to the area of the spell while they were discussing and pretended she wasn't paying attention; however, Castaspella knew she just didn't want to argue any further and only left after asking her, once again, to consider tutoring again.

Answers

Chapter Summary

Queen Glimmer manages to make her dad and her aunt have a calm, relatively polite, conversation, so they can work out their problems, and yet, the answers are insufficient. One conversation takes to another, but slowly some truths come to light.
Micah may not share his sister's opinion, but he needs to understand they don't *have* to agree either. Will the sorcerer finally get the message, or is it a lost cause?

»—That's why you began going to the Lunarium since then… You wished for her to be back to share that knowledge when needed— he realized. —I suppose I can understand the admiration— he admitted.
»—Micah— Shadow Weaver addressed him. He was both angry and ashamed, but listened to her this time. —You have all the right to be outraged, to hate me, and I don't expect or deserve your forgiveness… But, I can see you're full of questions you won't dare ask, so don't hesitate and ask away. That's literally what you two invoked me for.
»—No, I did it for her— he replied.

Later that day, Glimmer invited her aunt to have dinner with them; Micah had told her what happened and knew they needed to discuss the subject, so with her to moderate it should at least be a productive debate and not a mutual attack. However, the dinner went on almost purely silent, and Glimmer herself had to begin the subject.

—So… Will any of you explain this little incident with the summoning spell? How did it bound to you, Aunt Casta?— she asked, in her most diplomatic tone.

—I'm surprised your father hasn't explained it to you— she replied.

—I did.

—You only said she was reckless. That's *not* an explanation, dad— Glimmer pointed out, almost offended.

—Did she trick you into doing something? Or where you trying to achieve something else and accidentally bound the spell to you?— Bow asked, trying to keep them from starting an argument.

—Neither… It was an unexpected effect, I…—, Castaspella looked away a moment before finishing, —I only danced with her.

Bow's eyes opened as much as possible and Glimmer almost spat her drink. They both looked at Micah who's annoyed expression confirmed it was true.

—Ahem…—. The Queen had to clear her throat before she could ask —Could you maybe elaborate a bit?

Castaspella rolled her eyes and began —You know about the Guild Dances, no?—. Both Glimmer and Bow nodded so she went on —I don't know why I had never considered that, having been a tutor in Mystacor so many years ago, she had to learn the steps too, but… I just arrived at the Lunarium and the woman was dancing, which I'd never have imagined, and… You have no idea the scene I found. I *know* you three would have been just as astonished.

—None of that explains why you had no better idea than dancing *with* her. And during the *eclipse*! You can't tell me you didn't feel its power— Micah insisted.

—Look, I… I know you've been away for too long, so there's no reason for you to know this, but the truth is, I always organize the Guild Dances, *never* dance myself. I couldn't reject the offer— she replied with sincerity. —And yes, I felt- The energy of the eclipse has always been strong, but usually, I'd be guiding it to the Lunar lenses and nothing else. After all this time without needing to recharge a shield with that energy, I thought it was normal to feel so… odd.

—What did you feel, Auntie?

Glimmer's concern motivated her to answer honestly.

—It was like… the energy was trying to destroy me from the insides; it burnt, it seemed to be heating up my blood, my instinct was to resist it but I couldn't have tolerated it had I not let it flow— she admitted. —I suppose the dance *could* have influenced it? But in that case, we should be glad I accepted her offer or I'd probably be…

—But you aren't— Glimmer interrupted before she could actually say it.

—You know what?— Bow chimed in. —That sounds a lot like when Adora took the failsafe.

—Right! Though, as this is Etherean magic, it didn't harm her— the Queen agreed, following his lead to subtly digress.

—But it *could have*— Micah interrupted. This time, he looked anguished as he asked her — What if it destroyed you? Or… worse.

The three understood what he meant. What if she had been corrupted by magic too? Glimmer and Castaspella exchanged a look, neither knew what to say, but he needed an answer.

—Micah, I'm not going anywhere— she stated. —I won't force you to trust her, but I do. And I *know* she wouldn't have allowed anything like that to happen; you may not accept it, but I've seen her pain when she remembers what happened with you.

—She doesn't regret performing the spell— he sentenced, his tone weak and sad.

—Yet she admits it was a mistake, they both heard her— Castaspella answered calmly. — Although, what she *does* regret, is losing you.

—Why… just… Why are you suddenly so *involved* with her? What happened that she's always honest with you? And why do you seem to prefer her… over your own brother?— he asked, his voice barely audible, with an expression of deep hurt.

—I don't, Micah. If it's because I prioritize her advice…

—It is. Don't you trust me?

Castaspella took a deep breath and resolved —It's not a question of trust, but if I try to explain now… Ugh, it would be better if you just visit her with me tomorrow. Then you will understand it was merely a logical decision.

He sighed but finally accepted. Glimmer and Bow considered it a success and made sure the rest of the dinner went on smoothly.

As promised, the next day, the siblings went together to see Shadow Weaver. Coincidentally, on their way to the Lunarium, they saw her outside and preferred to go speak with her right there.

—Of all the places… Why the gardens?— Micah wondered, not intending to ask her, but she heard him and turned around with her eyes closed.

—It's much nicer than the Lunarium, don't you think?— she replied nonchalantly. But once she saw them, her expression changed. —Both of you again? Should I get used to it?— she mocked.

—Absolutely not— Micah quickly replied.

—Right, you could pay her a visit on your own sometimes, no?— Castaspella commented, somewhat defying him.

—Sure. He'd go on his own but to dismiss the spell— Shadow Weaver uttered. Almost instantly, she let out a smug smirk as she added —Ah, but that would mean I'd have to follow your sister around to feel less like a ghost.

Castaspella looked at Micah with a glare that kept him from voicing his indignation, but his expression said it all; he wanted to scream she was taunting him.

—If you don't mind, I have something of importance to discuss with you two— the Head Sorceress began.

—Can it be here? Now that you're around I can finally do some gardening— Shadow Weaver requested.

—What? Why, yes, but… why gardening?

—It's called a *hobby*.

—Hilarious— Castaspella retorted, rolling her eyes. She crossed her arms and said —Do whatever you want, I just need you to listen.

Shadow Weaver accepted, kneeled next to a patch of empty soil, and began cleaning out the weeds with ease. Meanwhile, Micah decided to ignore how odd the whole situation felt and simply listened as his sister retold a certain issue they had a few months before, with a magical beast that had been roaming Plumeria. She gave details of the creature's appearance, size, color, that it had feathers and claws, and how it had been scaring the people, destroying some yurts, and causing chaos. Once she had given the context, Castaspella asked him to remind her what he had suggested.

—Right… Look, I know it didn't work at all, but it was a big creature and none of our sorcerers know how to fight. Sending a large group was the only way they'd have a chance to eventually restrain it— Micah explained. —I only know the creatures in Beast Island, but believe me, I barely survived on my own, while that princess, Entrapta, kept building herself help and even enjoyed being on the island. So, of course, my logic was "more people, better chances".

When Castaspella looked back at Shadow Weaver, the sorceress had completely halted her work and stared at Micah in disbelief.

—So you ignored my advice of studying ancient magical creatures, didn't you?— she reproached him.

—Opposite to you, I didn't seek to get their "dormant" power or whatever you wanted from them— he retorted.

—You can sometimes be so narrow-minded, brother— Castaspella sighed.

—That creature attacking Plumeria was just *scared*. It's a very fragile creature, which is why it has such big claws— Shadow Weaver began explaining, in her teacher-like manner, almost pained at how obvious it was for her. —You should have sent a small group. What's more, the shorter the sorcerers, the better. Three would already have been too much, but if instructed to approach individually, crouching even, they would have won the creature's trust soon enough and it would simply be a question of guiding it away.

—What!? It couldn't be that easy!— he exclaimed.

—Actually, Micah, may I remind you the one who finally got everything under control was princess Perfuma herself? If it hadn't been because of her non-aggression philosophy, who knows just how terrible the outcome could have been.

—But we couldn't have known— he excused himself.

—She *just* mentioned she had advised you to study the magical creatures…— she pointed out. Before he could reply, she shook her hands and changed subjects. —Anyways. What I didn't tell you, is that, around a week later, I accidentally found some old documents, and one was a detailed investigation on ancient magical creatures, presumed to be long extinct, signed by "Light Spinner"—. Both Shadow Weaver and Micah stared at her with interest. —I found

that creature from Plumeria in her investigation. What she just explained? It was all in that document. So I realized I simply don't have what's needed to lead Mystacor, and that your help alone, Micah, isn't enough either.

—That's why you began going to the Lunarium since then… You wished for her to be back to share that knowledge when needed— he realized. —I suppose I can understand the admiration— he admitted.

—Micah— Shadow Weaver addressed him. He was both angry and ashamed, but listened to her this time. —You have all the right to be outraged, to hate me, and I don't expect or deserve your forgiveness… But, I can see you're full of questions you won't dare ask, so don't hesitate and ask away. That's literally what you two invoked me for.

—No, I did it for her— he replied.

—But the situation wasn't what you expected, was it?— she noted.

—Definitely not what I presumed… I can't believe how *good* your relationship is! You even call her "Cas", why would you call her that?— he expressed, indignant.

—Because she asked me to do so?

—What? Why!?

—Well, I just… wanted to be friendly. Every time she says my full name I feel like a little kid… And calling her "Shadow Weaver" every time felt a little aggressive— Castaspella explained.

—You have to be kidding me— he uttered in disconcert. —And why not "Casta", like everyone else?

—*Excuse you*, only Glimmer and you call me that; so, I feel it's more familiar— she pointed out.

—What do others call you then?

The Head Sorceress looked away a little ashamed.

—Either my full name or my title. I don't really have *friends*, Micah.

—What? But you're so cheerful, and nice, and care for everyone. We all know we can count on you for anything, or at least to support us, and you always do everything in your power to make sure your guests are comfortable. How aren't you more popular?— he asked, in complete disbelief.

—She's too smart, Micah. People reasonably feel inferior when she shows her skills. And when she doesn't, they simply can't stand her being so energetic. Not everyone has a natural charm— Shadow Weaver commented casually.

—Well, I may be too pushy sometimes. I just… As you said, I want everyone to be comfortable, but usually overlook what "comfortable" means for them— she continued with embarrassment.

—And yet you made friends with *her*— Micah pointed out, gesturing at Shadow Weaver.

—Because she isn't politically correct, like everyone else. She doesn't pretend; when I annoyed her, she said so to my face and was adamant. So I understood what I shouldn't do around her and, *presto*, I'm tolerable— Castaspella replied, mockingly at the end.

—Now you make it sound like I don't value your intelligence— the sorceress reproached her.

—What? Why would you? You know more than me!— she uttered, a bit perplexed.

—Your view of the world is different from mine, plus you have the brains to at least bring the important things to light— she assured her. —That's why I appreciated your insight regarding the Crystal or Arxia.

—If you say so…

Shadow Weaver made a resigned gesture and returned to her gardening. With their discussion finished, Micah started to leave, but Castaspella wanted to speak with him while she still dared, and gently stopped him.

—What is it?

—I need to ask…—, she said in a low tone, —Is it possible that you feel so betrayed, that you *still* feel so hurt with what she did, because she was a mother figure for you?

Both anger and shame reddened his face.

—Why are you asking me this now? She's right *there*!— he complained, trying to keep his voice down.

—If I go too far from her she can't keep gardening.

He was speechless for a moment, baffled and unsure whether she was joking or serious.

—It's ridiculous, Casta. Why would I see her that way?

—So you're telling me the moment I said "mother" you didn't picture Light Spinner?— she defied him. His expression was enough of an answer. —Listen, Micah. You had the privilege to have someone like that in your life. I… I was always alone; when we were little, you spent most of your time studying and practicing. When we grew up, you quickly met Angella, and… left. You know we rarely saw each other since you moved to Bright Moon and, after you disappeared, that we thought you were dead, I hardly saw Glimmer until she herself came to visit. Which happened rarely too— Castaspella explained. —So, I can't help feeling you're squandering an opportunity which, maybe, you just can't appreciate.

—I’m… Sorry. But, Sis, you can't just make me feel guilty for that. It wasn't my fault— he replied as gently as he could.

—I didn't mean to... E-excuse me, you're right. I shouldn't have said it like that. Forget it— she apologized.

Micah felt the need to say something more but couldn't find the words and finally gave up. As he left, feeling mentally exhausted, he forced himself to stop dwelling on the subject; he had made up his mind long ago, and there was no reason to change it now.

Castaspella remained in the gardens; she sat down a few meters away from where Shadow Weaver worked on the small patch of soil, and rested her head on her knees wishing she could just disappear on the spot, and eventually, she drifted off to sleep.

Young Promising Talent

Chapter Summary

The Head Sorceress finds herself adrift. After unintentionally manipulating her brother, she thought nothing could make her feel worse that day, yet she was sorely wrong. Just how *wrong* must she be if Shadow Weaver herself accuses Castaspella of trying to manipulate her?
However, an unexpected benefactor might be just what the sorceresses need to recover from such imbalance.

»—I'm fine. I'm sorry— she sighed. She felt weak and sat down. —I just need… a moment.
»—Of course— Shadow Weaver whispered. She then looked back at the kid and dismissed the illusion. When they looked back, she called —Come here, little one—. As the child arrived, they seemed to notice the grim mood and looked at the sorceress a bit confused. —Do you want to help me cheer her up?
»—Is she sad?— the kid asked.
»—A bit.
»—I'll help! What do I do?— they asked her excitedly.

About an hour later, a sorcerer comes to wake Castaspella up as a new group of kids has arrived at Mystacor. She quickly clears her drowsiness and follows the sorcerer as she notices Shadow Weaver has finished gardening for the time being. However, barely ten minutes later she's regretting her decision of trying to handle those kids on her own.

—No, please, come back here!— she exclaims, as one of them suddenly screams and runs off. She gestures to a couple of sorcerers who happened to be walking by to watch the group, and goes after the child. —Don't run away like that! It's dangerous!— she kept yelling, but the little toddler simply laughed and ran even faster.

They suddenly turned around a building and entered the gardens. Castaspella makes one last effort to run after them and arrives at the gardens completely breathless.

—Someone is full of energy, aren't you, little rascal?

Shadow Weaver was still there and the kid had run through her just a moment before. Slowly, trying to get her breath back, Castaspella approached the sorceress, who had created a small illusionary bird to entertain the kid.

—Ah… Finally. I can't believe… how quick they are— she let out.

Shadow Weaver smirked and addressed the child —Heard that, little one? You're faster than the grown-ups.

The kid giggled sheepishly and covered their mouth while looking back at Castaspella from their short stature.

The Head Sorceress sighed as she kneeled down in front of the kid, reproaching them with a severe tone —This place can be dangerous if you don't watch your step. You can get seriously hurt!—. The sorceress placed a hand on her shoulder to interrupt her, as it was obvious she was only scaring the child; her illusion quickly caught their attention again and they seemed to have instantly forgotten the scolding. Castaspella thanked Shadow Weaver and commented —No wonder you were the best tutor and raised the kids of the Fright Zone. You have a gift with children.

—It's not that complicated, Cas. You're just too genuine— she replied.

—You can't seriously mean it's mere manipulation?

—The way I see it…

—Or you refuse to admit you *can* be genuinely soft and gentle— Castaspella defied her. —Would it be so terrible?

—It would if you're going to look at me like *that* every time I charm a child— she retorted, making her laugh. —I rather you see me as a monster.

—Oh, come on. You're greedy for power, ruthless, and verbally violent, which both your girls have said about you. But that doesn't make you a monster, just… A person like everyone else, who happens to have really poor morals and anger issues— Castaspella considered.

—Should I be offended or just surprised you *actually* see me as a normal person?— she asked, pretending to barely care, as she kept her attention on the illusion to entertain the kid.

—If you want to be offended…—. The Head Sorceress couldn't keep herself from smirking and finally gave up. —Just take the compliment: you're great at handling kids, while I simply can't. If you accept teaching again, I'd really appreciate your help with this new group of children— she affirmed. However, she got suddenly nervous, and, panicking a little, added —These new kids are incredible, suddenly manifested powers out of nowhere, and they are so strong their parents begged us to take them in for training. I'm sure you'll be interested in this group.

Shadow Weaver froze a split second and the child noticed the illusion flickering for a moment.

With a severe tone, the sorceress asked —Are you trying to manipulate me?—. She sent the illusionary bird flying a few meters away from them for the kid to follow, and once they were out of earshot, she asked, in a frightening tone, —Do I have to tell you how *devious* it is to manipulate me with something like *this*?

She turned red up to her ears: Castaspella's mortification was all over her face, she covered her mouth and her eyes became watery.

—I'm sorry… I-I don't know why I'm doing this today— she apologized, her voice strained and her sight on the ground.

—Calm down.

—No, no. I should… Leave, I'll take the kid back and…

—Cas, breath— Shadow Weaver insisted, grabbing her left arm to keep her from leaving. —You've done this to someone else?

—I… Earlier I basically guilt-tripped Micah. I didn't mean to, but I clearly did or he wouldn't have felt like that— she explained.

The sorceress took a deep breath before gently answering —Let's say you were… learning this from me, whether you intended it or not. You're much better than that, Cas, and your reaction proves it; I wouldn't care if I was in your position—. Normally, Castaspella would have rolled her eyes, mocked her, or at least smirked. But this time she was too remorseful, maybe hadn't even heard her at all. Mildly annoyed at herself, she grabbed her shoulder pressing just enough to ground her. —Take a deep breath, now. You're panicking.

—I'm fine. I'm sorry— she sighed. She felt weak and sat down. —I just need… a moment.

—Of course— Shadow Weaver whispered. She then looked back at the kid and dismissed the illusion. When they looked back, she called —Come here, little one—. As the child arrived, they seemed to notice the grim mood and looked at the sorceress a bit confused. —Do you want to help me cheer her up?

—Is she sad?— the kid asked.

—A bit.

—I'll help! What do I do?— they asked her excitedly.

—Can you draw a circle? Like this— she said, crouching in front of them, and drew a circle in the air. The kid copied her and a light-green line appeared, forming a wobbly circle. —Use both hands— she gently instructed, correcting their movements a bit to fix the circle. —Now you add this…— she continued, gesturing what to do. —And now you activate it— she concluded.

The kid smiled brightly as a small illusionary bird, similar to the one Shadow Weaver had created before, appeared in front of them. They quickly realized it would move as they wished and made the bird fly in loops in front of Castaspella, making her smile faintly.

—I did it!— the child exclaimed proudly when she looked at them.

As they happily toyed with the illusion, Shadow Weaver offered her hand to the Head Sorceress to help her up, which she reluctantly accepted.

—You don’t need to lure me into helping you, understand?— she told her, holding her hand tightly as if to support her statement. —I have nothing else to do, you at least provide me *some* entertainment.

Castaspella laughed lightly, finally feeling better.

—Glad to be of assistance— she replied, giggling.

—Just make sure everyone is aware of this. The children, the parents, if they don’t agree with me teaching them, don’t push the matter. I know why I’m saying this— she advised.

—I can imagine… Um, I suppose the Lunarium could work as your teaching place?

—Cas, these are little kids. They will be much more at ease in open areas like this— she replied.

—Or you just want to keep gardening— Castaspella teased.

—Is it a family thing? Forgetting there are magical plants we *can use* for spells?

—Of course your gardening is magic-related— she mocked her. —I suppose it won’t be a problem, then, I’ll see to it.

—Much appreciated.

—And now, I should take this energetic future magician with the rest of the group— she sighed.

—Consider it a game— Shadow Weaver suggested. Looking back at the kid to address them, she said —Won’t you show the others your spell?

—Yeah!— they exclaimed, and ran towards Castaspella to follow her back, leading the bird as it flew over them.

Bold Belligerent Talent

Chapter Summary

Shadow Weaver is once again a tutor in Mystacor, even if now she's only a spirit and constantly supervised by Castaspella. This means, of course, trouble is not far away, and merely a week has passed when there's an "accident" big enough to dismiss the class and call a council meeting.

Yet surprises are barely beginning; and who knows what else might happen next.

»—What happened? Did you call the meeting?— he asked his sister. The next moment, he noticed the kid, his expression clearly furious, and Shadow Weaver equally furious behind him. —It's barely been a week. Just *what* happened?
»—Well, I believe he was a bit impatient to try the fire spell, and almost hit another student. A regular accident— Castaspella explained.
»—I see you caught the blow instead— he noticed, as she was still using the healing spell on her arm.
»—I instructed the children, repeatedly, that the spells should be dismissed once cast, *without* activating them. But he wouldn't listen.
»—As if they would believe you— the boy suddenly commented.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

As soon as Castaspella informed the Council that Shadow Weaver had accepted tutoring again, they called a new meeting to discuss conditions and have the full council approval. Surprisingly, it was the conditions set by the sorceress herself what persuaded most of them; wanting to have the children and their parents know who she was and, only if they accepted, put them under her tutelage convinced even Micah, and lingering concerns were eased by the fact Castaspella's constant presence was required for her lessons.

The next day, The Head Sorceress, two of the oldest council members, Micah, and Queen Glimmer, received all eleven children from that new group and around fourteen parents, as some of the kids had single parents and others were orphan teenagers.

The five sorcerers took their time explaining the particular conditions of their tutelage offer; there were already too many pupils in Mystacor and this was the best chance to keep the groups within reasonable amounts of students. Queen Glimmer summarized Shadow Weaver's story when she was alive, since her banishment from Mystacor to her sacrifice at the Heart of Etherea, and assured them this summoned form of her is perfectly safe, otherwise they wouldn't have considered letting her lead a class. Then, Micah and the old council members provided testimony about her teaching performance before her corruption,

her considerable knowledge, and the skillful sorcerers she had trained. Finally, Castaspella gave her word she would personally supervise the classes and be responsible for everything she'd do; the Head Sorceress explained she had a special spell that allowed Shadow Weaver to interact with reality when she was close enough, which would let the sorceress improve their casting like any other tutor would do.

With appropriate context, the parents were given time to discuss whether to give authorization for Shadow Weaver to be their children's tutor, and the orphan teenagers were taken apart to let the council know if they accepted or refused the offer. Surprisingly, all teenagers accepted almost immediately, and it didn't take long for the group of parents to make up their minds too. All eleven children would be in her class, and there was only one father who hadn't been fully convinced, while the rest completely trusted the council's judgment. The father who disagreed had been persuaded by his spouse and the rest of the parents that their kids would benefit from the classes and, no matter how bad Shadow Weaver had been, the council was in full control of the situation so she was harmless. Thus, despite insisting someone like her is a menace that shouldn't be near "young impressionable children", he finally agreed to let his son in her class.

The first week of classes began rather smoothly, Castaspella was intrigued seeing her so loosened when tutoring, and when the older council members went to check on their progress, they'd usually comment how she still taught in the same way as back in her time as Light Spinner.

However, it didn't take long for the first issues to begin. Shadow Weaver's introduction class was an incredible success, her natural talent to charm children won most of them over. Mid-class, the kid she had taught the bird illusion spell showed it to their classmates and the few who still feared her were so surprised they finally lost all fear. It was clear she was in her comfort zone when teaching, but her vices began showing during her third class, as she began identifying those "truly gifted" and Castaspella had to intervene more each day of the week since then.

—Magnificent— Shadow Weaver congratulated, as a girl managed to perfectly cast her fire spell. —Optimal balance between real and illusory fire. But…—, she looked at the girl next to her with whom she had been talking non-stop since the first class, —You would have achieved it faster if you didn't allow your *friend* here to distract you.

Behind the sorceress, Castaspella cleared her throat to call her attention.

—Well, well, there is no rush at all, don't you think?— she commented gently. —They only need to control their powers, and they have plenty of time now that all wars are over— she reminded her.

—I suppose— she replied with severity. —I'll go check on that boy. Hopefully, this time he will *actually* heed my advice.

The sorceress left and Castaspella looked back at the girls, who seemed disappointed after Shadow Weaver's remark. It was the last day of the week, and the woman had made comments like that almost every day. Castapella remained with them as she decided to try and lift their spirits.

—Don't take her seriously, she just has… very old beliefs she won't let go— she told them with a smirk. —But, maybe if you help your friend improve her casting—, she began suggesting the talented girl, —You can prove to her she's not distracting you at all! I'm sure you two can prove her wrong.

With her encouragement, the girls seemed more motivated, so Castaspella could move on.

—Cas, a little help, over here— the sorceress called her, as soon as she looked back.

The Head Sorceress noticed she was, in fact, trying to correct the form of the one boy who had been expressing his particular contempt for Shadow Weaver the past days, and this would be the first time he seemed willing to let her correct him. Once Castaspella was close enough, the sorceress carefully fixed the position of his hands and the fire spell was instantly stabilized. Satisfied, she instructed him to dismiss it, but instead, the boy activated the spell, firing it at the student in front of him.

—Wait!

—Stop!

Both sorceresses tried to stop him but couldn't. Castaspella only managed to cover the girl on the receiving end of the spell, while Shadow Weaver, with no magic to counter his spell, used an illusion to make him see darkness wrapping him. His spell vanished as fear overtook him, yet it didn't seem like the sorceress would drop the illusion any time soon.

—That's enough!— Castaspella exclaimed. Shadow Weaver froze a second and dismissed her illusion as she slowly retreated a few steps; then, the Head Sorceress addressed the boy, —You, stay right there and don't attempt to cast anything else—. Next, talking to the rest of the pupils, she informed —The class is dismissed. Everyone, return to your rooms in an orderly manner.

The girl she had protected from the fire was shaking with fear but as soon as she noticed she was fine, she followed the rest of her classmates out of the gardens and back into the building. Castaspella kept hidden her burnt arm until they had all retired and looked at Shadow Weaver who was clearly enraged.

—I cannot *believe* the audacity!— she complained, looking back at the kid. —Do you have any idea of what I could do to you for this!? Be thankful I'm merely a summoned spirit!

—Stop it!— Castaspella ordered. —You can't threaten the kids, even if they behave recklessly, you *know* that.

—So am I supposed to let it pass that he just burnt your arm!?— she asked, indignant.

—Very little of the fire was real, this is nothing. No one was badly hurt, you need to focus on that— she insisted. —But now, we have to inform the issue, and he will have to explain his actions.

Castaspella noticed she still had her hands closed in tight fists and gently grabbed them, exhorting her to calm down.

—At least let me help you heal— Shadow Weaver requested and drew a spell for Castaspella to copy. —Move it through the burn, it will ease the pain.

The Head Sorceress did as she instructed her while leading the way back into the building. The boy followed her, the sorceress walked close behind, all three of them in complete silence. However, before they reached the meeting room, to where all council members had already been called, they came across Micah.

—What happened? Did you call the meeting?— he asked his sister. The next moment, he noticed the kid, his expression clearly furious, and Shadow Weaver equally furious behind him. —It's barely been a week. Just *what* happened?

—Well, I believe he was a bit impatient to try the fire spell, and almost hit another student. A regular accident— Castaspella explained.

—I see you caught the blow instead— he noticed, as she was still using the healing spell on her arm.

—I instructed the children, repeatedly, that the spells should be dismissed once cast, *without* activating them. But he wouldn't listen.

—As if they would believe you— the boy suddenly commented. The three sorcerers looked at him with surprise, only to find him smirking for a moment before faking a pout. He then looked at Shadow Weaver, pretending to be scared, and tried to sound innocent as he said — She made me do it.

The sorceress's expression went dark, she closed her fists again and seemed ready to scare him to death, but Castaspella hastily got between them and held her by the shoulder while lecturing the kid.

—May I remind you… we all saw what happened, the whole class can testify if necessary, and when questioned they will confirm her instructions. So you better drop the act already, young boy.

—She's a menace! She can't be allowed near young impressionable children!— he claimed, angry once again.

Almost instantly, Micah looked at the sorceresses with a look of realization. He remembered the father who had said the exact same words and knew this was his boy, repeating his words and seemingly convinced of the same.

—I believe we should call his parents; maybe the whole class and their parents too, if we are to properly settle this matter— Micah suggested, and they renewed their walk to the meeting room.

—Quite a clever kid you are— Shadow Weaver commented, mischievously, as they walked. —All carefully planned to frame me; I would be impressed if you hadn't overlooked that we have truth spells too— she continued, and noticed the boy pale instantly. —Congratulations, kid, you're my favorite now.

Walking in front of them, the siblings heard her, and while Micah seemed disgruntled, Castaspella was completely amused and had to hold back a giggle.

Chapter End Notes

Quick question: Should I name those kids? The cinnamon roll from the previous chapter and this boy who became Shadow Weaver's favorite? I am literally writing the sequel without giving them a name, I just circle around calling them "kid", "child", "pupil" and making sure it's obvious who I mean...

Beatrix

Chapter Summary

As time passes, Castaspella falls once again in the belief she's not enough, and to no one's surprise, it is Shadow Weaver who will help her restore her confidence. However, if everyone thought they were close already, then there might be something surprising after all.

On the other hand, Micah reaches a new level of bothersome, and Castaspella's patience is running low.
»—Maybe I should leave— she said, trying to keep her tone neutral.
»—Wait, Casta— he called, and went after her. Micah stopped her before she could open the door. —Please, I'm worried about you.
»—No, you're not. You're just obsessed with the idea of the person who risked your life decades ago— she corrected him, completely serious. —I won't try to convince you to trust her, but stop forcing everyone around you to see her as a monster. She is not the person you knew— she insisted.
»—What makes you think you could possibly know her more than me?— he questioned her, indignant.
»—I don't think so. I *know* I understand her, who she was the moment she sacrificed herself, and because I've given her the chance to demonstrate who she is now, I am absolutely sure *you* don't know her at all— she sentenced.

Chapter Notes

Have I mentioned how much I like her real name? Yes? Well, I'll say it again: **I *LOVE* this name!!!!**

See the end of the chapter for more notes

A month goes by and, slowly but surely, Castaspella proves to the council how successful her idea was. In mere weeks, kids who had suddenly developed powers they couldn't comprehend nor control, are now in full command of them and have even been helping with the various magical crises that sprang throughout Etheria.

However, the Head Sorceress had her own crises too, and often found herself making efforts to handle the myriad of responsibilities she had without showing how much she was struggling. Her usual work doubled, and now she also had several new issues that were making her lose all patience, including that she appeared unable to properly tutor her assigned pupils, as she kept doubting herself or was too hesitant when giving instructions.

She desperately wanted to accept Shadow Weaver's help with that, and yet she was afraid it would make her look unfit to tutor.

But that was exactly what kept her distressed: she *felt* unfit to tutor, and she was trying to prove herself wrong, so no one except she herself would be able to help. After weeks of feeling worse and worse by the end of each day, she had become unable to sleep, always seemed irritable, and kept avoiding Glimmer and Micah.

However, she simply couldn't avoid Shadow Weaver. She had tried to keep it all strictly professional, solely assisting her for the classes and only looking for her when she needed her counsel but that spell, bound within her, was presumably letting the sorceress know if Castaspella was in distress, and the woman kept showing up every single time, including late at night when the restless Head Sorceress was seething with rage.

—Oh, stop doing that already!— she exclaimed, irritated, after being startled by the sudden apparition of Shadow Weaver through the closed door.

She noticed something had been thrown at her but didn't realize what until she looked at it on the floor. Castaspella was knitting before she arrived and had thrown it all together at her, the knitting needles with the piece she had made and the yarn ball.

—Have I… interrupted something?— the sorceress asked, mocking her a bit, as she picked up her things from the floor. Castaspella had approached, annoyed beyond imagination, and now seemed ready to snap at her. —Maybe I should keep this until you calm down so you don't throw it out of the window.

The Head Sorceress merely huffed and crossed her arms in front of her chest as an answer. Shadow Weaver followed her as she walked back to the couch and flopped down with a sigh.

—I did it all wrong anyways. It's too tight and looks disastrous, so I'm throwing it away regardless— she finally said.

The sorceress looked at her for a brief moment before suddenly seeming *very* interested in that faulty piece of knitting, amused even.

—Have you noticed "knitting" means the same as "weaving"?— she asked, taking Castaspella by surprise. She had no idea where that came from but it certainly caught her attention. —In the same way, knitting is not different from casting a spell. *This* proves as much— Shadow Weaver explained, holding the poor thing up before finally leaving it on a desk nearby. —Whenever I'd cast a spell in the same state of angriness you're now, or even just as nervous, my spells failed like your knitting. Every single time.

Castaspella's confused expression was noticeable as she asked —Why are you suddenly speaking about your imperfections? What are you…

—I need to get it through your thick skull that *no one* is perfect, including me— she interrupted. —You seem to have developed your admiration for me on the basis that I was the perfect tutor. I simply *strived* for perfection, it was a must to achieve the power I sought; it was my attitude, my calmness, and collectedness when casting, that guaranteed my spells

would work. And yet, I wasn't always perfectly controlled— she continued. —The times I impulsively used magic, when I was angry or even desperate, I was bound to fail. It backfired so many times when I tried to drag Adora back to the Fright Zone because I was too furious.

Castaspella looked away almost shyly.

—I… Understand— she let out. —I just can't… I can't handle things. Everything became so difficult so quickly— she let out. —And I understand what I *have* to do, but every single time I miss a different detail when casting.

—Maybe you're focusing on the *wrong* issue— Shadow Weaver commented. —In my opinion, you already have all the theory, all the knowledge books can give you. And just require some guidance to execute that knowledge. Haven't you asked Micah for help?

The Head Sorceress let out another sigh, annoyed this time.

—Yes, but he makes it look so easy it's… frustrating.

—Very well, I suppose I can give you a hand with that too, if you allow me.

—I don't…—, Castaspella began, but was interrupted by a yawn. —I don't want to ask more of you. No, no, I couldn't— she insisted.

Shadow Weaver took a seat next to her and said —I can't use sorcery anymore, but I can teach you just like I'm teaching the kids. And if you prefer, no one has to know—. Castaspella seemed a bit anxious, despite her weariness, so the sorceress encouraged her to lay down and used a bit of an illusion around her to reduce all sensory stimuli. —Once you can understand the practical side of spellcasting you'll have more confidence, all you need is to learn which details require your attention— she assured her.

—I suppose…—, she yawned again, —…I could use your help, Spin— she admitted. —Thank you.

Shadow Weaver looked at her as she slowly surrendered to sleep on her lap, and before she could dwell too much on why, she decided to confess to her —Beatrix.

—Huh?

—That was… My real name. Before "Light Spinner".

—I like it— she replied with her eyes closed, she was so sleepy her voice was a murmur. —Thank you, Bea.

The Head Sorceress finally slept soundly through the whole night while Shadow Weaver looked out through the window, silently reflecting. Only after sunrise was her meditation interrupted as she felt her stirring and reckoned she'd soon wake up. Intending to tease her first thing in the morning, the sorceress reached to gingerly grab Castaspella's chin.

—Look who's awake already?— she let out, mockingly, but stopped herself when the woman suddenly woke up, startled. Withdrawing her hand, she sternly asked —What happened?

She immediately noticed the sheer fear in her eyes; the Head Sorceress wasn't simply alarmed, something had completely terrified her. Shadow Weaver gave her a moment to recover as she was still gasping for air and then let her speak.

—I... I just ha-had... A nightmare. Th-that's it— she stammered.

—And what was it about?— the sorceress asked gently. —I recognize utter panic when I see it. I've provoked it enough times.

—It's nothing... A-as I said, merely a nightmare— Castaspella tried to dismiss her, nervously. However, Shadow Weaver's stare said it all so, looking away, she mumbled —It... was you... digging your claws into my throat...

The sorceress looked at the hand with which she had grabbed her chin before and, angrily closing her fist, commented —No wonder you were terrified, I should probably refrain from touching your face from now on.

—What? No, no. O-on the contrary. I-I need to remind me I have nothing to fear.

The Head Sorceress reached for Shadow Weaver's fist but she seemed unwilling to move her hand at all.

—Don't be reckless. If your instincts are warning you, it's for a reason.

—You can't really believe that— Castaspella let out. —I've been constantly told you're a menace; that was just my fear of being wrong to trust you.

—And I can't convince you that you are?

—Not a chance.

The sorceress rolled her eyes and finally loosened her fist; she could barely believe it when Castaspella placed her open hand on her cheek, leaned onto the touch, and took a deep breath, making an effort to counter her fright. It felt so strange for Shadow Weaver; the last time she had done anything remotely similar, she saw that same expression and instantly knew the sorrow she was about to inflict. But this time, she didn't want to hurt her like that.

As promised, Shadow Weaver helped the Head Sorceress every night, after she was done with her daily duties, and while it was easier than teaching the children, it proved to be a challenge regardless; Castaspella was too distracted and Shadow Weaver kept reminding her as much.

—I know, I know. I have to focus— she interrupted, before the sorceress could reproach her. —Just give me a moment— she asked.

—I wonder *what* is distracting you so much— Shadow Weaver mocked her.

—Should we apply your criteria?— she defied her.

—Are you trying to tell me something?

The sorceress only redoubled the challenge, which completely backfired on Castaspella.

—Ugh, I-I'm just tired, I'll go to rest— she stammered.

—Calm down, Cas, it wasn't serious— Shadow Weaver stopped her. —But I agree, you shouldn't continue now. Certainly, you're too distressed if you can't handle some teasing.

—*Your* teasing is of the most off-putting kind— she retorted.

The sorceress circled her and was now standing behind Castaspella, murmuring into her ear —Is it?

—This is what I'm talking about— she let out, knowing her face was reddening.

—Can't handle a little pressure? It's not like your life is in danger now— Shadow Weaver whispered as she held her waist.

—Please, Bea, don't— she sighed, feeling goosebumps.

The Head Sorceress seemed sad, almost as if she felt too weak to resist.

—Fine, no more teasing— she accepted, but didn't let go. —Just take a deep breath and relax. You're obviously not sleeping well, you almost dozed off in class this morning.

—I know— she yawned. —I haven't slept much since that night.

—But you *did* sleep back then— she recalled.

—Yes, because you helped… somehow, I don't really know— she answered.

—Why didn't you tell me? I can help you sleep again. That is… if you'd be fine with it after that nightmare. There are also potions to sleep…

—That's not an issue. But, no, no, come on!— she tried to dismiss her.

—Do I need to remind you I don't need sleep? It's literally no trouble at all for me, otherwise, I wouldn't be offering— she replied, mildly annoyed.

—Oh right, so you wouldn't help me if it was troublesome for you?— she asked, tilting her head back to rest it on Shadow Weaver's shoulder.

—I suppose if you asked nicely I would help regardless— she replied with a smirk, amused when Castaspella blushed furiously. —You began— the sorceress remarked before she could complain about her teasing again.

Within weeks, the Head Sorceress slowly went back to normal; she once again behaved cheerful, friendly, and patiently handled any issue brought to her. Noticing her "recovery",

Micah invited her to Bright Moon for lunch and to have a talk.

—I am happy to see you so well— he suddenly said, pleasantly surprising her. —We-erm, Glimmer and I, we were worried. We noticed you were so angry and irritable all the time… Are you doing fine, Sis?

Castaspella swallowed her food and replied —I'm fine, don't worry. I just had some difficult weeks.

—Is she giving you trouble?

—Oh, no, no. On the contrary. I was dealing with so many things and felt so distressed… She actually helped me manage— she explained.

—I see…

—Everything is fine, Micah. I won't deny I had a hard time, but it's settled now, really— she insisted.

—I trust you, but I can't help worrying— he expressed.

—And I'm asking you not to. There's no need, I promise.

—Put yourself in my place, Casta. I am *always* worried since you have her around at all times— he argued.

—If you trust me, shouldn't you know I *can* deal with her constant company?— she asked him. As he wouldn't answer, she went on —Look, she's not invasive at all, she respects my space, also likes enjoying her times of solitude, and whenever I require her, she's there to help. There's nothing to worry about.

—Don't you think… Don't you find it suspicious?— he asked, genuinely concerned. —Since when is she so respectful and thoughtful?

—You still think it's all manipulation— Castaspella realized. She suddenly lost her appetite, stood up, and abandoned the table. —Maybe I should leave— she stated, trying to keep her tone neutral.

—Wait, Casta— he called, and went after her. Micah stopped her before she could open the door. —Please, I'm worried about you.

—No, you're not. You're just obsessed with the idea of the person who risked your life decades ago— she corrected him, completely serious. —I won't try to convince you to trust her, but stop forcing everyone around you to see her as a monster. She is not the person you knew— she insisted.

—What makes you think you could *possibly* know her more than me?— he questioned her, indignant.

—I don’t think so. I *know* I understand her, who she was the moment she sacrificed herself. And because I’ve given her the chance to demonstrate who she is now, I am absolutely sure *you* don’t know her at all— she sentenced.

—This is why I think she has you charmed.

—That’s not true.

—She *is* a monster!

—No!

—She’s using you!

—Stop!

—You can’t really know her!

—No! *You* don’t know Beatrix, at all!

Both siblings suddenly fell silent. Micah was in shock, but Castaspella was just too furious and preferred to hold her tongue before she said anything else she’d regret.

—Is that… her *real* name?— he finally asked.

But the Head Sorceress simply looked away with her arms crossed; she refused to answer, and she didn’t want to stay there any longer. Micah didn’t really need an answer either, it was obvious his sister had, in fact, a profound familiarity with the sorceress he couldn’t accept but now couldn’t deny either. So he wouldn’t keep her any longer; he opened the door without a word and she left without even saying goodbye.

Chapter End Notes

Okay, I want to say something:
The nightmare thing was added after all 13 chapters were finished and "ready" to post, but around the time I posted chapter 6 I had this... idea? I don't know what to call it but I imagined, from Castaspella's POV, having that nightmare and waking up to well, what happened here, and I *wasn't* going to add it, until I remembered I had never stated a reason for that (SW helping Cas to sleep) not happening again until they actually talk about how she's not sleeping, so it seemed like a good addition after all.
Or I just like angsty moments
But I digress; the point of this note was to clarify I didn't write Cas's POV of the nightmare because it seemed too violent (believe me, when the idea came it literally froze me for a moment), and I preferred this tamer version in which she only speaks about it, which better fits the G-rating.

Trouble - Part 1

Chapter Summary

The time for the Guild Dance Castaspella loves to organize has arrived. She won't lose a second, this time it's bigger than on previous years and requires one more theatre company than usual, which means hiring Double Trouble and their troupe.
It seems like a greater event will be the least of her problems once the gossipers start feeding the rumor mill, but Castaspella can handle them without breaking a sweat. However, having such a trump card like Double Trouble in Mystacor, can she really be at ease? Will they make things worse or turn out to be of help?

»—Well, well, look at that— they said. —I wonder what has upset you so much.
»—You theatre people are all equally disrespectful— she uttered.
»—Oh, I see. You've met her— they realized. With a knowing smile, Double Trouble asked —And what did she say to upset you so much?
»—Don't play coy. She spoke about the bet between hers and your companies— she replied angrily.
»—No way! She dared tell you about it!?— they exclaimed. —I've never been happier to vouch for a friendship, believe me— they sentenced.

Chapter Notes

Writing Double Trouble is SO MUCH FUN!
Oh, gods, I should have given them more time but believe me, they kinda steal the spotlight a bit, and the freaking chapters are named after them for a reason, heh...

And the Theater Company thing is solely based on the fact that Double Trouble deserves their own group of actors to make a slightly more honest living.
And because they slay, that's it. Enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Time seemed to fly by; four months went on before anyone noticed, and suddenly it was already time for Castaspella to organize the Guild Dance, once again, for twice the usual people this time. Queen Glimmer had convinced the council to open the dance to any Etherian who would like to attend, and despite all objections, she finally got her way as she provided a solution for every issue the council presented.

Lack of space? Decor the exterior and gardens too, let the people mingle inside and outside. Not enough entertainers? Hire two different theatre companies, so there would be different

shows for the people to enjoy as they please. Food and drinks? There would be more than enough with Bright Moon's help.

And just like that, Castaspella gave in and organized the biggest event since Glimmer's coronation.

—Don't say it…

—I wouldn't say anything…

—But?

—But this is madness.

Whenever the Head Sorceress had to organize such events, she'd be seen frantically checking all preparations, walking up and down, solving issues left and right. This time, with the area of the Guild Dance increased, she would be seen all over Mystacor since early morning until late at night; and more often than not, the spirit of Shadow Weaver would follow behind, either speaking seriously or just annoying her.

This time, she *was* being serious and *also* annoying.

—Look, I enjoy organizing parties like this, so it might be "madness", or "too much", or "insane", or all the other things you've been saying the past three days, but for me, it's just the challenge of organizing a party even better than what everyone is expecting— Castaspella told her, showing her excitement at the end.

—I've noticed… your *enthusiasm*, and it's clear you relish doing this— Shadow Weaver admitted, speaking a bit condescending. —But it is madness that you're managing this all on your own— she clarified. —That's what I meant; I was mostly ridiculing you at first because I could never stand these events, but now I seriously think you're going overboard. Two theatre companies? Catering all the way from Bright Moon?

—All suggestions from *the Queen*, so I had little choice on the matter— she replied as if it were enough of an answer.

But Shadow Weaver's face said it was not reasonable, she wasn't buying it.

—Why do you have to be so naïve? They are taking advantage of you— the sorceress insisted, as she followed Castaspella down a crowded hall.

—Is that your professional assessment?— she mocked her.

—Very funny. But now that you ask it, yes, I would've played you just like this— she admitted.

The Head Sorceress stopped only to look back at her with fake indignation and holding back a laugh.

—Oh, great, so I'm being "exploited", no? Are you disappointed you're *not* the one doing so, or what?— she taunted her.

—Is it the lack of sleep again? That wasn't funny and was hardly clever— Shadow Weaver replied dryly.

—Ugh, never mind. I have to talk with that new manager to make sure she knows what her company usually does for these events— she sighed, giving up. —Go torment someone else.

The sorceress let her go and only watched from a distance as she welcomed a young woman, clearly from Salineas, and began quickly explaining a few things she couldn't hear from there. Glimmer approached from behind and she turned around before the Queen could call her attention.

—Queen Glimmer— she noticed. —Fancy seeing you here. Came to help your aunt by any chance?

—What? Oh no, she'd never accept my help— she replied, surprised at first but quickly distracted by Shadow Weaver's question. —But she's really *really* good at this, I'm sure she doesn't need the help.

—You clearly haven't been around your aunt the last three days, have you?— the sorceress asked, more like hinting at how wrong she was.

—It can't be that bad…

—She's so focused on organizing every little aspect of this cursed event, she almost walked into the wall three times only today— she told her.

Glimmer empathized with her pain but showed no surprise.

—She answers as she keeps walking, right?— she asked, and Shadow Weaver nodded. —Of course. How many things have broken already?

—None. Luckily, I caught them all— she replied, much to Glimmer's relief. —She thinks I'm only trailing her to get on her nerves, which I've done already. She hasn't noticed I caught the piles of dishes she almost hit or literally moved her away from the doorframes before she crashed into them.

Glimmer giggled, imagining those situations.

—Sounds like Aunt Casta, alright— she laughed. —I… I'll try to get her some help. Still, thank you for watching out for her— she sincerely welcomed.

Before the sorceress could answer, the spell bound to Castaspella called her attention and made Shadow Weaver look back at her, only to find she was engaged in a less professional and more casual conversation with that theatre company manager. A moment later, she appeared behind the Head Sorceress, who was softly laughing at whatever the woman had just said and, upon noticing her, quickly changed her expression.

—I see you're back.

—How observing— Shadow Weaver mocked her. —I spoke with Glimmer, she'd get you some help. Maybe you'll be able to stay in the same place for even longer than you just have.

—I told you I didn't need help— she calmly replied.

—And I told you they are overworking you— the sorceress insisted, copying her tone.

Castaspella's expression of mild contempt was met with a smirk and the Head Sorceress could only roll her eyes as she wondered how she would survive her.

—Oh, wow— the theatre manager sighed, and both sorceresses suddenly remembered she was still there. —It seems I've lost the bet, huh?

Any trace of shame left Castaspella as she severely asked —What bet?

—Oh, just a silly thing with the other company you hired— she tried to brush it off.

—If it's so silly, surely you won't mind explaining what it entails— Shadow Weaver pressed.

—It's… ah, well. As you two have been the talk of the town almost everywhere in Etheria, and we usually play bets against the rival company, when *you* hired both of us, we just *had* to take the chance.

—What does that mean? A bet about *us*? Regarding what?— Castaspella asked, starting to lose her patience.

—Whether you're like friends or it's all manipulation. But seeing you two now, a friendship sounds less wild than I thought— she replied, with such brutal honesty it shocked the Head Sorceress.

—Well, that was just plain rude— she commented, unamused. —I've already told you all your predecessor knew, so I'm done here— she sentenced and walked away as if suddenly on a rush.

Shadow Weaver, however, remained a moment, staring at the shameless woman who seemed entirely oblivious to how unpleasant she had been. The sorceress finally left when Castaspella was far enough, so she could go straight to the gardens, and never noticed the smirk on the theatre manager once she turned around.

The outside of the building was also full of actors and equipment. These were the people from Double Trouble's company, and they saw her arrive at the gardens through the wall. Shadow Weaver was seething and she'd probably be burning something if she still had her sorcery. Yet Double Trouble didn't hesitate a second to approach the sorceress.

—Well, well, look at that— they said. —I wonder what has upset you so much.

—You theatre people are all equally disrespectful— she uttered.

—Oh, I see. You've met her— they realized. With a knowing smile, Double Trouble asked —And what did she say to upset you so much?

—Don't play coy. She spoke about the bet between hers and your companies— she replied angrily.

—No way! She dared tell you about it!?— they exclaimed. —I've never been happier to vouch for a friendship, believe me— they sentenced.

—We're *not* friends.

—Then what should I call you? What do you two have?— they asked, unamused.

—It's… a relation of non-manipulative mutual assistance— the sorceress replied, rolling her eyes and pretending she hadn't just come up with it.

—*Right*. Whatever it is called in your language— they mocked.

Shadow Weaver huffed in annoyance but still wanted to know —What matters here is you didn't think I was manipulating her. Why?

—Oh, dear, I wonder if you'll believe me— they replied. —Let's just say I knew *something* had changed; since we learned of your sacrifice, I feel like you're an entirely different character.

—Get to the point, I'm just as willing as usual to make you regret it if you drag this on longer than necessary— she threatened them.

—Fine, fine. Listen: when She-Ra basically saved us all and restored Etheria, no one asked where you were because, following your usual behavior, we simply presumed you had fled to avoid any possible punishment for your past crimes and such— Double Trouble began, and it didn't really surprise her. However, her expression changed as they continued —But when Catra revealed she had the remains of your mask, *finally* someone asked about you, and I happened to be close by to listen. They were in tears retelling how you had sacrificed for them. *Oh, it was so tragic!* No one was expecting that from you—. Shadow Weaver noticed they were being honest, despite the drama, and let them go on. —So now, when your students spread your story, about how you had been summoned to Mystacor and have been teaching them with her help, I realized you no longer fit the old image we had of you and I couldn't judge you by that as everyone did. So I trusted your friendship- ah, excuse me, your "relation of non-manipulative mutual assistance".

The sorceress held back a snicker and instead asked —Who was it? Who asked where I was?

—Oh, can't you guess?

—I swear, Double Trouble, I *will* scare you to death if you keep testing my patience.

—Fine! It wasn't even that difficult!— they complained. —Your sorceress, of course. Castaspella was the only one who asked, and after everyone heard the story, she said

something about… reviewing collateral damage? I don't recall her pathetic excuse, only that it was bad enough to seem suspicious so I followed her into the woods.

—Why doesn't it surprise me?

—I am *so* considerate, right!?— they teased. Her expression was enough to make them quickly continue —Well, I trailed her for a while until she considered it was far enough she wouldn't be seen and… I suppose she was blowing off some steam? She began cursing furiously, hitting trees, and I can swear I smelled smoke the moment she drew some spell in front of her—. Their face became more serious, as they narrated —My first instinct was to take the form of a random Plumerian and pretended I was just passing through when her tantrum called my attention, so she never activated that spell. To think she was so angry she first shouted at me…

—All of that sounds very hard to believe— Shadow Weaver commented, telling herself Double Trouble was playing with her.

—No, no. I promise, I'm telling the truth— they insisted. —I asked her why she was like that and she only said she was upset for someone who had died before they could defeat Horde Prime; I baited her and mentioned we had only heard of *you* as the sole casualty, so she gave up and admitted your death had unsettled her— they continued. —I sat with her for maybe half an hour as she expressed her frustration, sorrow, and anger. I think I can even replay part of her rambling, give me a moment— they said, and took Castaspella's form to perform what she had said. They cleared their throat and, with her voice, began —It's… it's like a joke! Like… the worst prank ever! I had *finally* convinced myself it was worth a shot: inviting her to Mystacor, maybe convince her to help us, even if it took me years, I… ugh!—. They imitated her anxious walk, up and down, and how she'd let out all her frustration with her endless verbosity. —I was so *sure* I could give her a chance and prove it was worth it! And had she run away… well, there are plenty of spells I could have tried to track her down, and maybe it would have taken even more convincing but… but she *is* dead—. They came to a stop but stayed in her form, apparently, they weren't done. Double Trouble sat down and hugged their legs in a way Shadow Weaver had seen Castaspella do before, and continued — I can't… I realized too late we had been unfair with her, and now I'll never make it right.

Only then, Double Trouble returned to their usual form and stood up again. Before they could ask, Shadow Weaver gave them feedback on their performance.

—You got her expressions right, but her voice never goes so shrill, even when indignant it stays low-pitched.

—Ah, someone pays attention— they teased. —But thank you very much, that's extremely useful.

—You better not have deceived me— she insisted, making an effort to ignore how the spell was telling her Castaspella possibly needed her.

—I was a hundred percent honest— they assured her. —Remembering this made me firmly believe it wasn't impossible for you to have a proper… "non-manipulative relationship", against all logic.

Before the sorceress could further question them, Castaspella arrived at the gardens and walked up to them visibly annoyed.

—Are you ignoring me!?— she asked Shadow Weaver.

The sorceress noticed the shape-shifter's expression, and first explained —The spell that gives me density near her also allows me to feel her distress and know if she needs me—. Even when addressing Castaspella again, she remained poised as if nothing had happened. —But I was *busy* this time. What was so urgent you couldn't wait a few more minutes?— she nonchalantly asked back, determined to pretend her conversation with Double Trouble never happened.

—You have *no idea* of what is happening inside— she began, absolutely annoyed. —The actors have been gossiping everywhere and now all of Mystacor is talking about *you* being jealous!— she explained, feeling aggravated. —Even Micah heard them commenting on it!

—They are *what*!?— the woman asked with sheer fear in her eyes.

—You're… oh, my. It's true— she realized, which only horrified Shadow Weaver more. —If it wasn't true, you'd just dismiss it with a laugh, Spin. But right now you're *terrified*!

—Stop it! Don't say another word!— the sorceress ordered, though it sounded more like a plea.

—Just tell me what happened. I *know* my brother will try to question you about it, so better tell me the truth and I'll see what I can say to calm him down— she requested.

—Aw, how *sweet*! You're so protective of her— Double Trouble teased.

—Remember you're here solely because Queen Glimmer requested as muchh, it's a favor. Don't give me reasons to kick you out— she warned them.

—Oh, of course, my apologies— they replied, and left with a flourish to check on their actors.

The sorceresses walked further into the gardens but everywhere seemed to be full of people. They ended up arriving at the beach where the lilac and pink clouds come and go with a soft rummage.

—I suppose the reason why it would *look* like I am jealous, or acted jealously, is because of how I interrupted your conversation with that theatre manager while you seemed so amused talking to her— Shadow Weaver finally commented, walking a few steps ahead from Castaspella.

—Oh… Really? I… I actually thought you chimed in because of how I wished someone would interrupt us soon— the Head Sorceress admitted. —It was fine at first but then she kept me on a conversation loop and I found no way to break away from it. I felt so fake only pretending I wasn't uncomfortable.

Shadow Weaver didn’t look back but had turned her head to the right to listen more clearly, and held her hands behind her back.

—Well, none of that matters. What they saw is what they will gossip about. But I am *not* jealous— she firmly sentenced. Castaspella let out a faint smile and walked up to the sorceress to hug her back. It barely startled Shadow Weaver this time, but she asked —What is it that you find so enticing about my back to always feel compelled to do this?

—It’s comfortable— she laughed, resting her face on the sorceress’s loose hair. She let out a deep sigh before finally answering —I don’t know why, I just wanted to. Felt like it.

With a smirk, Shadow Weaver noted —At least it’s less invasive than your normal hugs.

—Good to know— she giggled.

They stayed like that for a while, in silence, and the sorceress gently held Castaspella’s arms around her, like a wordless request to grant her a few more minutes of that small comfort.

Chapter End Notes

I wrote this before even posting the first chapter, but now I can say: Double Trouble literally says what half the comments say, I'm baffled! XD
Also, this looks terrible, but this was my shot, back in October, at TRYING to illustrate that last scene in this chapter. It was 100% self-indulgent, so I don't really care it passed unnoticed (”^_^)

Trouble - Part 2

Chapter Summary

> Who could have imagined even after the event wrapped up there would be another show waiting to go down? Castaspella certainly not, and even if Shadow Weaver would have rather dealt with it herself, her condition wouldn't allow her.
>
> Before the curtain falls, those who thought they knew the Head Sorceress will witness an entirely different side of her. And they are *not* ready at all.
> »—And I would rather each of you explain your own actions. So go look for your accomplice in the council, or assume full responsibility; regardless, we shall hear what your daughter has to say about this once she's back.
> »—Are you threatening me? I'm not a scared little boy you can push around— he complained.
> »—Poor sweet Micah, I am *not* the one you should worry about— she assured him, holding back a smirk.
> »He hadn't noticed before, but Castaspella was staring at him expressionless; he would have preferred obvious rage, indignant cries, just *any* emotion, because if she showed nothing, it meant she simply wanted him back on Beast Island.

Much to Castaspella's delight, the Guild Dance turned out to be one of the best events Etheria had seen in decades, and it went on without a hitch. She was so satisfied with the results, she completely ignored the small gossip issue. It was true that Shadow Weaver's absence during the event only fed the rumors even more, but the Head Sorceress couldn't care less, and soon everyone had almost forgotten all that gossip.

After the event, it took the theatre companies a whole day to gather their belongings and finally leave Mystacor, during which Castaspella had to make a conscious effort not to roll her eyes at the looks that followed her; it was only the actors now, but it became so bothersome she could have snapped had they stayed a minute longer.

Noticing as much, Shadow Weaver preferred to keep herself busy alone, so she wouldn't make it worse for the Head Sorceress. Annoying her wasn't half as fun when it dragged on for so long. However, she didn't mind it when Castaspella herself went looking for her, and toned down her mockery to let the woman have a moment of peace.

—Back to your gardening, I see.

Shadow Weaver heard behind her and continued to work as she answered —What else can I do for now? The classes restart tomorrow.

—Right, of course.

—Did you need anything? If someone *happened* to see you here with me, alone, the rumors would increase again— the sorceress warned her, still tending to her flowers.

—Am I not allowed to come and speak with you if I want to?— she asked, between annoyed and indignant. —And you could look at me when we're talking, no?

Shadow Weaver shook the soil off her hands and stood up facing Castaspella.

—Of course, I never meant to say you can't— she replied with a smirk. —Now you have all my attention, happy?

—Thank you— she uttered, looking away.

—Any reason in particular to be so grumpy today?— the sorceress asked, walking closer. —What has you so tetchy?

—Drop it. If you realize I'm not in a good mood, why do you bother me?— she complained.

—I am trying to help. Speak up, I promised not to tease you until those buffoons are gone— she reminded her.

—Very considerate of you, Spin.

Shadow Weaver didn't miss a beat. Creating an illusion, that made it seem like something was grabbing their neck, she hissed —Take off her appearance. Now!

Double Trouble revealed themselves and looked terrified.

—It was a job, I didn't mean… any harm— they explained, gulping hard as the sensation of squeezing felt all too real around their neck.

—You will tell me exactly who and for what hired you.

—Yes, yes, just… clear the illusion! Please!— they begged. As soon as she dismissed it, they dropped to the ground gasping for air. —How did you even *do* that?— they asked. —No, forget it. I rather not know— they changed their mind. They took a deep breath and stood up again, brushing the dirt from their clothes. —Listen, I was handsomely paid, I couldn't refuse. But I suppose I could return without results if you tell me how you realized it was me — they offered.

—Do you want to suffocate again?— she threatened.

—I *will* tell you everything about who hired me, but I still should report back and I'd gladly give no useful information at all in exchange for this tiny favor.

Shadow Weaver seemed mildly surprised as she commented —Your morals are more twisted than mines, I'll give you that—. She took a deep breath, trying to control her anger, and said —Having fixed the voice, it was flawless; exactly her behavior, even for private circumstances like this. You had me fooled, Double Trouble, and *that* is difficult to achieve… or forgive. But the fatal mistake was calling me "Spin".

—What?— they exclaimed. —She calls you that! I-I remember!

The sorceress almost cackled at that.

—Which is exactly why that gave you out! When we're alone, exclusively, she's been using another nickname no one has heard. Mostly because I asked her not to use it in front of others — she replied, with a hint of malice.

Double Trouble grinned deviously.

—Now *that* is juicy, worth more than just my silence— they considered. —So let me warn you: you shouldn't act impulsively. If there was ever a moment for your well-thought plans, that's now. Otherwise, this could cause her… difficulties.

When Shadow Weaver found her, the Head Sorceress was walking back to her room, finally done with all her duties and at last free from the annoying gossipers.

—I need you to come with me. Now— she told her with severity, confusing Castaspella.

—I'm sorry, what?

—Let's go, Cas, we have to find your brother and Glimmer— she insisted, grabbing her wrist to pull her along.

—Why!? What happened? Please, tell me *something*, Bea— she pleaded.

—You'll know soon enough. Now we have no time to lose.

—Well, Glimmer isn't even in Etheria right now, remember? She left this morning with Bow, Adora, and Catra, on a mission into space— she reminded her, following the sorceress who still gripped her wrist.

—How convenient— she uttered. —Then Micah it is, and he better has a great explanation.

Castaspella gave up on trying to make her speak and simply followed resignedly. Minutes later, they had found Micah sorting a few documents that he had to take to Mystacor's archive. At first, he intended to ignore them, but he couldn't help noticing how Shadow Weaver was holding his sister's wrist and left everything.

—You owe us an explanation— the sorceress accused him.

—*I* owe *you*? I should be saying that when you barge in literally holding hands!— he countered.

She released Castaspella, who was still very confused, and continued, with the same accusatory tone, —Stop being a baby. And don't try to deflect. Double Trouble told me everything. You, Glimmer, and that councilor who plotted with you, have a lot of explaining to do.

He looked surprised at first but seriousness quickly overtook his expression. There was no point in trying to deny it. He cursed under his breath and grimaced as he looked back at them.

—If you already know, why come asking for explanations?— he asked rudely.

—I don't care why you felt the need to hire Double Trouble for *that*, but your sister deserves to know why you had them pose as her— Shadow Weaver retorted. —And I would rather each of you explain your own actions. So go look for your accomplice in the council, or assume full responsibility; regardless, we shall hear what your daughter has to say about this once she's back.

—Are you threatening me? I'm not a scared little boy you can push around— he complained.

—Poor sweet Micah, I am *not* the one you should worry about— she assured him, holding back a smirk.

He hadn't noticed before, but Castaspella was staring at him expressionlessly. He would have preferred obvious rage, indignant cries, just *any* emotion; because if she showed nothing, it meant she simply wanted him back on Beast Island.

—I'll go for him— he decided, leaving the room to find the council member Double Trouble had told her about.

Both sorceresses followed closely, making sure he wouldn't try anything funny. Shadow Weaver remained mostly calm, but Castaspella next to her was a bomb about to go off. The sorceress held her shoulder, grounding her, and merely gave the Head Sorceress a look to let her know she *had* to calm down.

Moments later, the women stared at Micah and a very ashamed sorcerer who was literally sweating since he saw them. He apologized again and again and quickly began explaining they never meant any harm and it was all out of concern for her.

Any doubts Shadow Weaver had about why Castaspella is the Head Sorceress of Mystacor vanished when she realized the immense respect the council has for her; they would usually contradict her, challenge her, even make decisions against hers, but it was because she had always encouraged them to do as much without thinking her title meant her word was law. She was fair as a leader and preferred them to be genuine in their decisions and opinions, even if it meant they disagreed with her. Now, when he had aggravated someone as reasonable and understanding as her, it was natural for the sorcerer to feel so utterly ashamed.

—We have been concerned since the beginning, I admit it was unfair not to trust you, but we were worried— he expressed, repeating himself once again. —It is difficult for us to believe we wouldn't be fooled again; none of us could have foreseen what happened with Light Spinner back then, and now we are afraid it might happen again if we're not careful— he admitted. Castaspella noticed Shadow Weaver's expression: she agreed with him on that. —We… we have been considering that she might be subtly influencing you, and the gossip from the past few days put us all on edge. So we asked Queen Glimmer to authorize us to…

spy on you, and see if there were any reasons for concern—he explained, unable to hold her sight. He cleared his throat a few times before continuing —Obviously she refused, it was maybe too extreme of us to suggest it, yet we insisted that we had to be sure you weren't in danger, so she offered us an alternative to spying; she never agreed with any of this, yet preferred it in order to preserve your privacy.

—Double Trouble…— the sorceress noted, with a severe tone.

—Yes. We hired the shape-shifter and arranged a "test" of sorts to reveal your relationship's power dynamic without having to spy on you— he explained. —It was still disrespectful for which I apologize sincerely. However, our intentions weren't evil, please know we meant no harm— he begged.

—I can see you genuinely regret your actions and seem to have acted out of honest concern — Castaspella stated. —Still, it is clear you did *not* think it through and let yourself be influenced by my brother, for which I advise you to be more cautious from now on. Consider who will be affected by your decisions and what has led you to such conclusions in the first place.

She spoke with severity but remained calm, appearing almost unrecognizable for both Micah and Shadow Weaver, who hadn't seen her acting like that before. But the sorcerer's reaction suggested this was to be expected from her when she had to handle a situation of this caliber.

She then looked at her brother, who immediately looked away and crossed his arms in front of his chest.

—Fine, sorry. I shouldn't have dragged them into this— he finally said, clearly unapologetic.

—No, you shouldn’t— she agreed. —I said I wouldn't force you to trust her, yet I *will* have to order you to stop encouraging others to doubt her as you do— she sentenced. —You have *no* idea what you have done— she concluded.

Castaspella turned around and left before he could reply, and Shadow Weaver was unsure whether to follow her or ask Micah the one thing she had been wondering about. Oddly enough, it was the councilman himself who asked exactly what she had been thinking.

—Why was it so worrying how everyone commented that Shadow Weaver was jealous?— he began, speaking in general. Then, he addressed her to say —She explained to us it was actually that you helped her out of an uncomfortable conversation she was unable to leave without seeming rude; I see no issue with that—. The sorceress nodded and the councilor continued, addressing Micah, —Then why did that make you believe it was concerning at all? Even before we knew what had actually happened… why would mere jealousy be dangerous, King Micah?

—It was *obvious* she wasn't jealous— he asserted, much to Shadow Weaver's surprise.

—I cannot believe this— she let out almost instantly. —If you're saying it like that, it means you simply can't stand the idea of such a rumor being true. Am I right?— she challenged him.

—You *actually* prefer I was manipulating her than ever consider I *could* have been jealous… because of what it would entail.

The sorcerer opened his eyes in realization and stared at Micah as his face reddened.

—You already got what you wanted. Go torment someone else— he uttered, refusing to reply.

It was barely noticeable, but there was a hint of pain in Shadow Weaver's expression, one that couldn't be hidden by her mask now, yet remained unseen as neither sorcerer noticed.

Castaspella wasn't in her room, or the gardens, or the Lunarium. Shadow Weaver kept going around Mystacor trying to guess where she was, as she had no idea how to find her without sorcery. However, as soon as the Head Sorceress let out her despair, she just knew where to go.

Down with the Crystal of Arxia, Castaspella sat in silence, tears streaming down her cheeks which shone faintly with the light emitted by the restored crystal. Shadow Weaver had no idea why she was hiding *there,* but preferred not to break the silence; she only sat next to her and laid back against the wall.

—Go ahead, say it— she finally mumbled, her voice broken from crying.

—Of course not— the sorceress replied, guessing what she meant.

—But you were right. I'm just a fool, being used, all too dumb to even notice, under the illusion of being a leader— she insisted, repeating things the sorceress had been telling her.

—I take it back.

—What!?

—All of it, I take it all back. I was- I wanted to believe it was the truth, that I was opening your eyes to a fact, but I had no actual proof. Now I have, but of the opposite— she explained. —I was wrong.

—What are you talking about?

—The council has such great respect for you, I am almost envious. It makes sense, however; they respect you for things I would have never done, which is why the council members rarely supported me when I was still Light Spinner. They acknowledged my skills and expertise, but that was it.

—They respect me? What… Ugh, please, stop with your games.

—I am serious, Cas. I had no idea why they would choose *you* as Head Sorceress, being so… Gentle. You allow, even encourage, them to contradict you. I was sure only ruling with an iron fist would lead to a prosperous future— she stated. —You proved me wrong. Your

leadership has earned the council's respect, that man may have offended you but he recognized as much and looked as if he wanted the ground to swallow him on the spot— she insisted. —I still believe they are a bunch of fools, but even a broken clock is right twice a day, no? They were right to choose you as Head Sorceress and, again, when you offered to make Micah the Head Sorcerer but they elected to keep you regardless.

—I… You really think I'm a good leader?— Castaspella asked, looking away.

—I believe so now, yes. I am gladly surprised to have been so wrong about you— she admitted.

—Thank you, Bea— she sobbed and got closer to rest her head on Shadow Weaver's shoulder. —I think I needed that.

—You don't say— she mocked her, making Castaspella laugh weakly.

Spies

Chapter Summary

The Best Friends Squad is back in action, and after so long since the last time they had a mission on Etheria, it could be said their mission together went almost without a hitch. However, Glimmer and Catra may be regretting their life decisions now; or plotting how to convince Micah he should quit chasing ghosts. At the end of the night, all they know is he needs to find a hobby, anything other than relentlessly hating Shadow Weaver.

»—Right, right— she sighed. —Even the worst-case scenario can’t be that terrible, right?
»—Exactly! Which is why your dad should lay off a little— Adora replied.
»—Ugh! But *what* can I tell him!?— she exclaimed. —Everything sounds either like an obvious lie or like something that would *still* freak him out!— she stressed.
»—We just have to assure him nothing evil is going on— Bow stated. —And, well, that it’s just… eh, meetings?
»—Late at night…
»—To practice magic? We heard them talking about perfecting the teleportation spell— he insisted.
»—Yeah, but we only saw them practicing the magic of disturbing us— Glimmer answered sarcastically.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

For a whole month, Micah left his sister in peace. He would only go to Mystacor for his pupils, or to participate in any council meetings, and then returned to Bright Moon as soon as he was done with his duties. Castaspella felt a bit relieved, but it still pained her that he would ignore her like that.

—Perhaps if I wasn't around you all the time he wouldn't avoid you so much— Shadow Weaver inferred, while the Head Sorceress was busy taking off her cape.

She was seated on the couch in Castaspella’s room, pretending the subject didn't upset her at all, but she couldn't fool the woman now. Either because she could see her face or because Micah was her weak spot, her sorrow was evident to her.

—Don’t say that. It's not your fault— Castaspella assured her as she approached. —This isn't our first disagreement, and I've survived his absence before. At least now I know he will eventually come around. He may hate you forever but he wouldn't push away the last of his family. And Glimmer always speaks with her father, encourages him to be more

understanding, even wants him to give *you* a chance— she told her, as she sat next to the sorceress wrapping her arms around Shadow Weaver's shoulders.

She had her back at Castaspella and made no move to remove her arms, on the contrary, she leaned onto her. The Head Sorceress pressed her cheek against the sorceress's and cupped her other cheek, wanting to cheer her up.

—Your optimism won't simply transfer to me, you know?— she mocked her.

—Wouldn't it be great if it could?— she teased back, gently turning her face to properly look at her.

A sudden noise startled them and Castaspella let go of her to check the door, as it sounded like someone had knocked. Yet there was no one outside, so she returned and sat again, facing the sorceress this time.

—Maybe Micah is right. You should stay away from me— Shadow Weaver commented.

Something seemed to have motivated her sudden pessimism, but Castaspella didn't dwell on it. She grabbed her hands and held them tightly, rendering the sorceress speechless.

—I don't want to. I've learned so much from you, Bea. I hadn't improved my spell casting so considerably since my graduation, plenty of years ago— she assured her.

Shadow Weaver closed her eyes for a second, but then simply smirked and replied —Then we better make it worth it. You still haven't perfected the teleportation spell. I suggest we go to the Lunarium tomorrow and try again until you get it right.

—I appreciate it— she thanked her with a soft tone, before kissing her on the cheek.

Moments later, in the gardens of Mystacor, five figures appeared under the cloak of darkness. Glimmer had teleported herself, Bow, Adora, Catra, and Melog, all invisible until moments before.

—Everyone saw it, right!?— Glimmer asked, her eyes wide open. She laughed nervously and added —I think I just hallucinated that. Yeah, I must have…

—You didn't! *I* didn't! And I need to throw up now!— Catra replied, just as distressed, kneeling and supporting her weight with her hands. She grasped the grass tightly and added —No, I won't. But, ugh, I should.

—Um… Glimmer…— Bow called, as he placed a hand on her shoulder. —Are you okay?

—What's going on? Why are you two so disgusted?— Adora asked. —It was only a kiss on the cheek!

—It was *more* than that!— Glimmer quickly retorted, indignant. —I swear, if Bow hadn't tripped and hit the door, they would have kissed or something!

Adora was still confused and asked —Well… Maybe? But, why do you find it so gross?

—Do you understand what any of that meant?— Bow asked, genuinely concerned.

—Ugh! How can you be so chill, Adora!?— Catra exclaimed. She finally stood up and looked furious as she rambled —It's so nasty! How can anyone be that *touchy* with Shadow Weaver! And it really looked like they were going to kiss!

—Hey, tone it down. It's very late and someone might hear you— Bow warned.

—Look, Arrow Boy, if you hadn't startled them, everyone on this floating island would have heard me!— Catra retorted.

—Don't even say it— Glimmer uttered. —Ho-how can they be so close!? *When* did this happen!?— Glimmer screamed.

—You too now?— Bow complained.

—Come on, guys. Why are you so annoyed?— Adora insisted. —I know Shadow Weaver isn't exactly… uh, sweet, or affectionate at all, but it's not so strange that someone as loving as your aunt managed to grow on her— she innocently commented. The three of them stared at her with deadpan expressions, and even Melog looked confused. —Guys, remember when I said I needed to know if the woman who raised me still had any good in her, at least *very* deep inside? Well, there it is! She's like anyone else but, clearly, it required someone specific to get her out of that shell of bitterness and cruelness. This can be a good thing!— she went on.

—You're so innocent; you have no idea what that meant, Love. And you don't *want* to know — Catra replied, with an expression of utter incredulity.

—Just hear me out. It's clear Castaspella brings out the best of her. When we first spoke with Shadow Weaver since her death, she admitted she never accepted her feelings, like how much she cared for us.

—Instead, she was just unapologetically hypocrite— Catra retorted.

—Okay, true. But maybe this means now she's actually learning to accept what she feels!? She might finally be more genuine like you wanted, Catra— she suggested optimistically.

—Like *I* wanted? What!?— she exclaimed indignantly.

—Uh, yeah. Remember the alternate reality when you activated the portal? You gave us the perfect Shadow Weaver— she reminded her.

Catra huffed and uttered —Because the real one was a nightmare. That's *exactly* why this is so unbelievable!—. Looking back at Glimmer, she said —Sparkles, your aunt is done for if your grumpy father learns about any of this. You need a plan.

It seemed like Adora still wanted to argue her point, but Bow shook his head in silence while Glimmer panicked next to him.

—What am I gonna tell him!? It's obvious now that Shadow Weaver is *not* influencing Aunt Casta at all, it could even be the opposite! But I *can't* tell him any of this! Ugh!

—We can tell him anything believable, he would never find out— Catra stated. —But only you would know what could be plausible enough so that your father buys it.

—But what if he sees them!? He'll know I lied!— Glimmer insisted.

—Well, we *did* just spy on a private moment back there. They are nothing like that in public — Adora remarked.

—You're right. They are even worse!— Glimmer sentenced. —Look, I told you since Double Trouble's fiasco he's been insufferable about this, but you have *no idea* the stuff he's been telling me! He rambled so many times about how odd their teasing is! Like… They are uncomfortably playful! He was *particularly* annoyed about a joke Shadow Weaver made back when Aunt Casta went to offer her to teach again.

—But… That was months ago— Bow realized.

—I know!— she exclaimed indignantly. —It just stuck with him because of how shocking it was and how easily Aunt Casta dismissed it— she explained.

—What did Shadow Weaver say?— Adora asked.

—Well, she was with dad at the Lunarium and said, these were her words, that she had a "*proposal"* for her and…— she laughed a bit, interrupting her explanation. —And Shadow Weaver asked if she wouldn't kneel first!— she continued, finally bursting out laughing. — His *horror* when he told me!

Glimmer kept laughing, Bow covered his reddened face and stared at Adora, who was still processing, while Catra had no idea what any of that meant.

Finally, Adora realized and exclaimed —Wait, as in *marriage*!? And he was *right there* listening!?

Bow nodded silently, and Glimmer calmed down little by little so she could talk again.

—He was *so* mad, especially because Casta gave it no importance at all! She just scolded Shadow Weaver, but in a playful manner too, and told her to "shut up and listen"— Glimmer recounted.

—And she's still alive after saying that— Adora noted, a bit shocked.

—Hold on, what's "marriage"?— Catra asked.

—Well, you know… Like Bow's dads? Or Glimmer's parents? Or Netossa and Spinnerella? — Adora explained.

—What!?— she yelled. Her surprise didn't last long as she realized —That's *very* gross but sounds like her; his reaction is *just* what she wanted—. She crossed her arms, forced herself

to bear the disgust, and asked Glimmer —You know Castaspella better, Sparkles. Do you think- You know, could she feel… Anything for someone like Shadow Weaver?

Her face fell as she replied —I don't really know. She never had many friends but has always been a very friendly person so… It's difficult to tell whether she feels something for her or just doesn't want to be alone. I'm not sure.

—And what about Shadow Weaver? Do you think she could?— Bow asked them, uncertain.

—Erm… Well. We only knew her after the corruption. Just *the* Shadow Weaver, not who she was before— Adora began. —I always trusted there had to be some good in her, beneath all that cruelty, and… Knowing she *chose* to be evil, I no longer doubt that woman *could* be good if she decided to.

—Which means—, Catra continued with disgust, —It's difficult to know whether she's *somehow* using your aunt, or if she actually considers her a friend, at least.

—How can we even begin to think about real romantic feelings, or rule them out?— Adora questioned.

The night dragged on as Glimmer brainstormed feasible stories to tell her dad; Catra and Melog disappeared at some point but no one noticed as both Adora and Bow were too focused on Glimmer's ideas.

—Ugh… I can't believe I'm doing this— she sighed. —Last time I suggested hiring Double Trouble to *avoid* this and now *I* went to spy on them, after apologizing and saying I shouldn't have let dad harass them… If they ever know about this, Aunt Casta will make sure I *never* forget how much I've aggravated her— she rambled. —But, what if we're making a mistake? If we say nothing and then dad was right…— she suddenly panicked.

—Hey, babe, calm down— Bow gently advised. —We may not be certain of what will happen with those two, but we *know* for a fact that Shadow Weaver is harmless now, okay? Nothing that terrible can happen, not anymore— he assured her.

—Right, right— she sighed. —Even the worst-case scenario can't be that terrible, right?

—Exactly! Which is why your dad should lay off a little— Adora replied.

—Ugh! But *what* can I tell him!?— she exclaimed. —Everything sounds either like an obvious lie or like something that would *still* freak him out!— she stressed.

—We just have to assure him nothing evil is going on— Bow stated. —And, well, that it's just… eh, meetings?

—Late at night…

—To practice magic? We heard them talking about perfecting the teleportation spell— he insisted.

—Yeah, but we only saw them practicing the magic of disturbing us— Glimmer answered sarcastically.

Adora cackled, mostly because of Glimmer's face of disgust, and finally noticed Catra wasn't there when she looked around to see if she was laughing too.

—Wait, Catra and Melog are missing. When did they leave?— Adora asked.

Bow looked up and asked —Both of them? You don't think she went back to…

He was interrupted by Catra's sudden apparition; as soon as Melog dropped the cloaking magic, she rushed to Adora and grabbed her shoulders.

—We have to go, now, now. I saw nothing, let's leave now!— she sputtered.

—What happened?— she asked seriously.

—Nothing, nothing! I do *not* acknowledge the last half an hour! Or this night as a whole!— she replied, so frantic it was clear she wouldn't reveal anything else. —And we leave early tomorrow, can we just focus on that? I need to get as far from this planet as possible… now!

—She won't tell us what happened, will she?— Glimmer noticed.

—Yeah, no— Adora replied, a bit concerned. —But she's right, we leave early, remember? We can't delay it anymore, and it won't take more than a week, we'll be back soon.

—Right, yeah, I almost forgot. Thank you for helping us with this, Catra. Really— Glimmer expressed.

—Yeah, and… Sorry for whatever you saw?— Bow added.

—I saw nothing!— she yelled.

They couldn't help laughing a bit before Glimmer finally teleported them all back to Bright Moon.

Chapter End Notes

Erm, in case you're curious about what Catra saw (seriously, she represents the phrase "curiosity killed the cat" here), let's just say it's an eliminated scene because I rather this remains G-rated, heh.
BUT, because I can, I'm also posting the full eliminated scene as an E-rated work (after all, it technically *happened*), so you can elect to omit it (as it doesn't disturb the plot), but if you are either curious or em... in the mood, you can check it out at your own discretion.
-In other news, on Saturday (25th, around noon, UTC -3), I'll start posting daily, for a

week, a "festive fic" I wrote to eh... counter the festive-season depression. Anyways, it's an AU, sappier than my usual, but I wanted to announce it somewhere-
Thanks for reading ;)

Chapter updates are every Wednesday, around noon, Argentinian time (UTC -3)
Hope you enjoy it ^_^

Shattered Mask

Chapter Summary

All tensions peak in Mystacor at long last: Castaspella is finally confident enough to confront Micah and also accept her own feelings; Shadow Weaver, despite being dead, fears for the first time in too many decades; and Micah's rushed decision may have unfathomable consequences.

»He had asked as many people as he could about the time she and Shadow Weaver investigated the Crystal of Arxia, and everyone told him more or less the same: they had formed some kind of alliance because he had been chipped and they solely cared about freeing him from Horde Prime's control. However, some had also mentioned it was quite odd how they suddenly seemed like old friends, of the type who would annoy each other for fun, just like he witnessed after summoning her, and now Glimmer and her friends had assured him there was nothing devious going on, only plans to keep practicing magic; apparently, their dynamic is still just like during his chipping.
»All of that felt *wrong* to him.
»His reflections finally made Micah return to Mystacor. He simply couldn't accept any other idea, it *had* to be that Shadow Weaver was manipulating her. Because if she wasn't… No, it simply couldn't be. Ever.

Chapter Notes

Please, I'm begging you, don't hate me too much by the end of the chapter (TT-TT)
(You can always go read the festive fic for some comfort, you know?)

On an anecdotic note: the beginning of the chapter is a novelization of my morning the day I began writing this chapter, I'm not joking. The gardeners arrived while I was still asleep and I had to jump from bed and get changed in a rush to go explain where and what they had to do, so…
Okay, I still hope you enjoy the chapter (^-^)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

A knock on the door of her room woke up Castaspella. She wasn't aware of how late it already was, or the fact that she had been literally resting her head on Shadow Weaver's abdomen while hugging her hips. She had completely forgotten about it all and, half asleep, asked who was there.

—The gardening teams have arrived, Head Sorceress. They await your instructions for this year.

Whoever was on the other side of the door seemed extremely nervous and, as soon as they had informed her she was needed at the entrance, they left without delay. Castaspella awoke fully in an instant and practically jumped out of bed when she heard their steps furthering, seemingly trying to rush out behind them.

—Stop right there— Shadow Weaver held her. —Have a bit of self-respect. Change your clothes and at least wash your face— she compelled her. —Just look at you, if you rushed out like that…

—Don't say it! I know, yes, you're right. I got… a bit anxious— she apologized and walked into the bathroom.

—Only a bit?— she asked, sarcastically, raising a brow. —I suppose if you had gotten out I could have kept you under an illusion of your usual look, but at some point, someone would have noticed— she teased her. —Yet I admit it would have been *so much fun* to watch.

—I would be completely offended if I didn't know you're just teasing— she replied from the bathroom while drying her face. When she returned, she opened her closet door so she could get changed behind it. —Won't you try to convince me of how you'd actually enjoy seeing me embarrass myself?— she asked, as the sorceress had kept silent.

—After seeing how stubborn you can be about your trust in my *real* intentions, I prefer not to waste my energy— she replied with her usual severe tone.

—Should I think it's considerate of you or that you just gave up?— she questioned her, closing the door of her closet. She turned around to get her cape and, as she was putting it on, she felt Shadow Weaver gently grabbing her loose hair to tie it up on a bun. —Thanks for doing that every morning— she whispered shyly.

—After that fright I gave you… It's the least I can do, no?

—That's why you do it!? Really!?— she questioned her, skeptical.

—*Fine*! No, I just want to do it. Happy now?

Castaspella could hardly keep herself from smiling at that but preferred to ignore her teasing.

After a few moments of silence, she asked —You really think I should wear it loose?

Shadow Weaver continued to handle her hair and replied —I thought you were asleep already.

—You know full well, no matter how tired I am, sleep never comes easy.

—Indeed, I've noticed. My illusions help you sleep because I prevent all external stimuli from reaching you so nothing keeps you alert— she reminded her, as she finished fixing the bun in its place.

She turned around, picked up her crown, and thanked the sorceress —I appreciate you stopping me earlier. I could only think I was already late and…

—I'm not surprised I have to remind you to respect yourself as much as you respect others, Cas, but I will say this only once: you are the Head Sorceress, if you need some extra sleep they have to respect that too and wait until you *can* receive them, no matter who they are.

—But they lose daylight if I don't hurry to take each group to the areas we need them to work on.

—What can ten minutes be?

—Well, if I *could* cast that teleportation spell properly…

—Do it now. I'll fix it if necessary, and tonight you'll repeat it until you make it perfectly— Shadow Weaver prompted her.

The spell did need some fixing but, in barely a minute, the Head Sorceress appeared down at the entrance, where several groups of people, most of them from Plumeria, had been waiting for her. One by one she took each of them to the area they usually handle and left them to work once she had specified just how much they had to reduce new foliage or whether the new sprouts were to be pruned or not.

When she went to the gardens with the three usual people, they quickly noticed the new plants everywhere around, and Castaspella realized she forgot Shadow Weaver had slowly spread her "hobby" around the whole place; she barely noticed before, possibly because the sorceress kept her *distracted.*

—I realize this is very chaotic, but please do be careful with the plants— she requested in her most diplomatic manner.

—Are… these plants expensive?— one of the gardeners asked, as they closely inspected a very strange and twisted one.

—Not that much, it's just that they were planted by a dead woman. Quite rare, no?— she innocently replied, trying to make a joke.

—Oh, of course. We understand, we'll make sure not to ruin them— they assured her before finally setting their tools on the ground to start working.

Castaspella realized they actually *didn't* understand, but refrained from correcting the mistake as it was maybe too much to explain.

That day, Shadow Weaver's class began later than usual because Castaspella was busy with the recharge of the Crystal of Arxia and, afterward, it also dragged on longer than it should have. However, the sorceress had been meaning to have at least one night class at some point,

so she welcomed the chance to finally have it. They realized about six of the pupils were stronger at night, and four others were weaker. This also left the question of why one of the children was completely unaffected, but all of them seemed fascinated with the discovery and even relieved to know the problem wasn't them, only the time of the day.

—…This leads me to believe it's because of his parents that he has an affinity with both day and nighttime— Shadow Weaver finished explaining.

—So your "favorite" student happened to be the only one empowered by the sun and the moons? What a coincidence…

—Very funny. You know he's my favorite for his devious mind. He's cunning… and could learn a lot from me besides sorcery.

—That's not going to happen.

—I presumed you'd say that.

—Changing subjects—, the Head Sorceress interrupted, —What was all your complaining about the classes and practices times?

—I know it's no longer allowed to have classes at night, but if at least they could have practice time after the sun has set…— Shadow Weaver argued.

—Look, nighttime classes or practices are considered dangerous— she reminded her. —And if they are learning to control their magic during the day and at night it's just stronger, they should be able to command it regardless, no? Why would they need to practice at night?— Castaspella asked her.

The sorceress halted and turned around to look at her while asking —I suppose you have never handled more power than what you're used to, am I right?

—Well… The only time I actually *had* more power than usual was… Eh, remember that dance during the eclipse?— she admitted. —But I didn't use the power at all so…

—Suffice to explain— Shadow Weaver interrupted. —In that case, if you had *tried* to use that power, you would have gotten yourself hurt. So much energy has enough strength to overload your spells; if you aren't used to such energy, it backfires— she explained. The sorceress traced Castaspella's jaw with a claw while adding —You wouldn't want those kids to get hurt just because their power is unexpectedly strong, right?

—What are you doing?— the Head Sorceress asked, trying to keep a straight face and holding back a smirk as the woman got closer.

—Seeing how long it takes you to fluster again.

Suddenly wary, she asked —No, for real. What's going on? This is literally coming out of nowhere.

—We have an audience— the sorceress whispered. —I was trying to lure him out of hiding.

—This can’t be…— Castaspella sighed. —Excuse me, but I'd rather be direct— she apologized. Rising her voice, she spoke out —Come out now. We know you’re there, Micah.

Leaving his hiding spot, the sorcerer scoffed —So you noticed. Meaning *that* just now was on purpose?

—Very observant— Shadow Weaver mocked him. —Would it upset you if it wasn’t?

Castaspella cleared her throat and interrupted —Spin, stop. Don’t start.

—Oh, no, no. Let her, Sis. I want her to elaborate on how she’s using you to irritate me.

—That’s so egocentric of you to say, Micah. And quite disrespectful, even. I am *not* using your sister, nor would I ever for something as petty as disturbing you— the sorceress affirmed without hesitation, which inevitably delighted the Head Sorceress.

—You really want her to believe so, don’t you?— he challenged her.

—I would ask the same, but it’s clear you don’t care for what she believes. You are desperately trying to convince *yourself* I’m merely using her, aren’t you?— Shadow Weaver reckoned.

—Enough, you two— Castaspella finally interrupted with severity. —Micah, please leave now. This is the first time *in a month* you actually interact with either of us; if you’re only going to bother us, I beg you to continue ignoring us instead.

—What!? Why are you so rude to *me*? I can’t believe you’ll defend *her* and accuse me like that!— he complained.

—No, no. I am not being rude, Brother. I’m stating a fact— she replied seriously. —Listen. You have made a point of demonstrating how much you hate her, and that you prefer avoiding your only sister instead of merely tolerating her presence around me— she remarked. —And no matter how much it pains me, I have to ask you to stay away as you have been until now. Because *this*, spying on us and jumping into arguments… I have no reason to endure it, Micah. I don’t want to push you away but I don’t want to fight either, so I’m asking you to leave now, for all of us’ sake.

He grunted and looked away, but after a moment, accepted defeat and walked away.

On his way back to Bright Moon, he simply couldn’t stop thinking about it. How could it be? His *own* sister had become so close with the woman who almost got him killed! He could still remember, before getting chipped, that Castaspella was *so* angry about that event. What had happened since?

He recalled when she told him about the time she and Angella interrogated Shadow Weaver, she even ranted for a long time about her constant mocking. But he had chosen to ignore it when she expressed concern for the woman as they had seen her agonizing, clearly suffering more than anyone could imagine. That had led to a conversation about the price of the power

she sought and, ultimately, he couldn't change her mind: she was sure just *anyone* could end like her, especially he, who already had so much power. But what if there was something else to her worry? What if her sudden concern and her previous annoyance at all the mocking from Shadow Weaver originated from the same feeling? What if Castaspella wasn't simply being compassionate as usual but rather held her in special regard?

Of course not! It was just her personality! Micah had always admired her gentleness, how she deeply cared for everyone more than herself, and he knew she had to be suffering a lot now that they always argued. That's why he refused to believe the sorceress wasn't just taking advantage of Castaspella. He had asked as many people as he could about the time she and Shadow Weaver investigated the Crystal of Arxia, and everyone told him more or less the same: they had formed some kind of alliance because he had been chipped and they solely cared about freeing him from Horde Prime's control. However, some had also mentioned it was quite odd how they suddenly seemed like old friends, of the type who would annoy each other for fun, just like he witnessed after summoning her, and now Glimmer and her friends had assured him there was nothing devious going on, only plans to keep practicing magic; apparently, their dynamic is still just like during his chipping.

All of that felt *wrong* to him.

His reflections finally made Micah return to Mystacor. He simply couldn't accept any other idea, it *had* to be that Shadow Weaver was manipulating her. Because if she wasn't… No, it simply couldn't be. Ever.

He knew they would be in the Lunarium practicing spells and, entering the building, he made sure to stay unnoticed. Micah just had to see for himself if there wasn't some form of manipulation going on.

Castaspella was in her fifth or sixth try already, missing once again a tiny detail that made the spell fail. They were using an old useless book to test the result, and it already had several marks and cuts, evidencing how dangerous it would have been for her to use the faulty spell.

—Just *how* did you turn a practical spell into an offensive one?— Shadow Weaver mocked her as she circled the Head Sorceress. She stopped behind her and fixed the position of her hands. —You're making this like your knitting that night, remember? Too tight— she gently explained as she separated Castaspella's arms, widening the area of the spell. —And the teleportation spell opens a rift in the fabric of space, meaning such a small spell forces the book throw a narrow fissure that keeps tearing the poor thing.

—Wait, really!? Why didn't you mention it before?

—The priority was to finally make it work, and I expected you to realize how it operates by then— the sorceress replied, releasing her arms. She then placed her hands on either side of Castaspella's waist, and teased —Are you not paying attention?

—Why are you so obsessed with the "distraction" thing?— the Head Sorceress asked, turning her head to face Shadow Weaver. —It's almost like you fear being distracted yourself, Bea—

she taunted.

—As if— she replied with a smirk. The sorceress only held her waist tighter, yet the next moment, she whispered —Break-time is over, try again.

Shadow Weaver let go of Castaspella and stepped away giving her as much space as possible. She expected the Head Sorceress to try the spell on the book once again, but noticed a moment too late she was actually casting it on herself. The split second she disappeared the sorceress froze, suddenly feeling a fear like she hadn't felt since she was alive… even worse than when the Spell of Obtainment failed.

However, she couldn't even process that feeling before Castaspella reappeared, right in front of her, safe and sound. With great happiness, she laughed and hugged Shadow Weaver.

—It worked!

—I thought you promised not to hug me again— the sorceress said, struggling to hide her concern from a moment ago.

Castaspella released her but immediately smirked and, feeling emboldened, countered —Oh, sorry. Would you prefer this?

She leaned forward and met Shadow Weaver's lips, completely fixing her in place; she kissed her, without hesitation or embarrassment. But it merely lasted an instant as the sorceress suddenly drew away.

—Wait! No!— she cried out, staring at something behind Castaspella, moments before her summoned form lost its density and vanished into thin air.

She felt her disappear. Too shocked to react, her eyes started to burn and her sight blurred. The sorceress fell on her knees, barely paying any attention to the waned spell on the ground. The noise inside her head wouldn't let her think, but the sound of footsteps behind her shook her senses and returned Castaspella to reality.

She didn't need to look back to know her brother was standing there, having dismissed the spell. His hands were still soaked from the water inside that small stone pool, from where he had extracted the remains of Shadow Weaver's mask to completely crush it between his hands.

He didn't do it deliberately, merely reacted to quite an unexpected scene, without questioning whether it was too extreme or actually correct. It just *had* to be right.

Micah finally broke the silence as he stood behind her and demanded —You better have a *great* explanation for this, Castaspella.

But she remained silent. She closed her eyes and finally let her tears fall. He deserved no words from her, she wouldn't even look back at him. In a single second, she had lost it all again; the feelings she had struggled to admit were met with a sudden nothingness.

Chapter End Notes

I know!
That was **extremely** mean, but I promise there will be more!
By February 2022 I'll have enough of the sequel written to start posting, I promise!!
Also, FYI, I don't hate Micah, I swear, but I… may or may not have this idea that he has to go through a bit of a villain arc; as Shadow Weaver's historical pupil this simply *fits*, and of course he'll come around, just wait for it.

Finally, the sequel was actually intended to be an epilogue, and this *crushing* ending was intended to force me to finish the story here (cause it kept getting longer!). I decided to add an epilogue because this was too sudden to finish there, but it *also* has become much longer than intended, which is why it's a sequel now. I would love to start posting it already, but I actually finished this draft back in October, and then had to work for my Exchange assignment due in November *and also* prepare my finals. So… Yeah… It is now December, I have some stuff written but it's not nearly over, so I will have to wait a while to begin posting *Throw away The Mask*.

Thank you all for reading, bearing with me, and I hope this was still enjoyable despite the **extreme** slow burn and this… frankly heartbreaking ending.
Until next year it is.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!